

WIKIMEDIA COMMONS

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How a Delhi friendship became an alleged handler pipeline

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

Mohammad Sahil and Sameera were not professional spies. They were a young couple from east and south-east Delhi, and investigators say their lives came into contact with an intelligence network based in Pakistan via Instagram.

The friendship developed into a marriage, motivated by the promise of money. Sahil, who is 25, grew up in Sarai Kale Khan; his father, Mohammad Asafak, hails from Badaun in Uttar Pradesh and is a car mechanic. He obtained a bachelor's degree through IGNOU and worked for a lawyer, having at one time expressed an interest in studying law.

In June 2025, he quit that job and was without work

when the police arrested him. Sameera, who is 21, resided in Shakarpur. Her father, Nadeem, moved to Bijnor in 1996 and nowadays sells cold drinks and water bottles in local markets. She completed her schooling at a girls' school in Keshav Puram, obtained a distance-learning degree and worked at a call centre in Noida.

The police state that Sahil and the other man had been friends before Sahil came into contact with a Pakistani agent on Instagram in 2024. According to the investigators, it was Sameera who made the introduction. The initial contact was not presented as spying; it was a social media conversation that, over time, led to a second introduction: the original agent connecting the two with a Pakistani intelligence officer.



(L-R): Sahil and Sameera

As Sahil told during his interrogation, the person in question developed those

connections. The deal was that they would be paid money for the work they

did. Eventually, they got married. At that stage, the relationship with the han-

dlers shifted from chatting to actual tasks. The work was not glamorous, and the pay was poor. Between 2024 and 2025, the couple is said to have obtained eight Indian SIM cards and sent them to Pakistan via Dubai; in return, they were paid around ₹30,000.

The investigators claim that the cards were used overseas to create WhatsApp accounts that seemed to be Indian. These accounts could then contact people in India, join up with local groups, and gather information while appearing to be from India. The jobs did not end with just the logistical aspects.

The police claim that Sahil was instructed to locate other people who could keep an eye on the cantonment areas in various parts of the country and to gather information

about army personnel whose court-martial cases were still pending. According to the officials, Sameera was in charge of a large part of the SIM purchases and distribution. Investigations into two recovered phones indicate that the conversations on both phones linked them to the same Pakistani contacts. Counter-intelligence teams will recognise this kind of recruitment pattern.

A platform designed for casual interactions serves as the first point of contact. A person already known, in this case, a friend who eventually married the individual, helps reduce suspicion. The handler then takes over from the original contact and talks about easy money. It gives the person small, deniable tasks: to buy a prepaid card, to pass a packet to a courier

route that goes through a third country, to find information about a military case, and to look for someone willing to visit a cantonment.

The tasks are cheap; if they are successful, they provide a foreign service with an Indian telephone number, an Indian face, or an Indian pair of eyes. It will be up to the courts to decide whether the couple understood the full purpose of the SIMs or only the fact of the payment.

What the police outline is a slow decline: starting with friendship, then moving on to Instagram, marriage, a few thousand rupees, and finally a list of jobs that included a call-centre worker in Noida, an unemployed law aspirant, and people they had never met in person. The amount of money was small, whereas the supposed deal was not.

Delhi roads come to a standstill on Raksha Bandhan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A particular kind of gridlock visits Delhi only a few times a year, when the roads fill not with office traffic but with people carrying sweets and gifts, hurrying to reach a sibling before the day runs out. Friday was one of those days. As the city marked Raksha Bandhan, its arteries seized up from the Delhi-Meerut Expressway to Akshardham, turning a festival of quick visits into hours spent staring at brake lights.

Long queues of vehicles were reported through the day on the Delhi-Meerut Expressway, MB Road, Kalindi Kunj, Dwarka, Kashmeri Gate, Sarai Kale Khan, Anand Vihar, Rohtak Road, Pragati Maidan and Akshardham. The Delhi Metro, too, saw a heavy rush of passengers, with several stations reporting a sharp influx through the morning and afternoon.

The congestion on the Delhi-Meerut Expressway had actually begun before the festival weekend and continued for several hours on Friday, with vehicles crawling and traffic teams deployed to manage the flow. MB Road in the Chhatarpur area saw similarly long queues stretching for considerable distances, while the Lado Sarai Old MB Road traffic signal witnessed its usual congestion, with commuters this time also raising concerns about buses jumping red lights and blocking pedestrians at zebra crossings.

Kalindi Kunj, a stretch that has become something of a daily bottleneck for the city, saw commuters describe the Friday jam as no different from any other day, only worse. Traffic snarls were



also reported around Pragati Maidan and the Akshardham stretch, while movement slowed on the Delhi-Saharanpur Highway near Geeta Colony Road as festival traffic built up. With demand for rides surging through the day, auto and cab aggregators raised their fares, according to reports, as commuters scrambled for transport options amid the congestion.

Anticipating the rush, the Delhi Traffic Police had issued an advisory ahead of the festival, warning of increased pedestrian and vehicular movement on August 27 and 28 around Anand Vihar ISBT, Road No 56, NH-9 and Vikas Marg. Commuters were advised to avoid these stretches where possible, plan their journeys in advance, and allow additional travel time.

Alongside managing the congestion, the traffic police also ran a road safety campaign titled "Rakhi ka waada, suraksha ka iradaa," combining enforcement with a symbolic gesture: women police officers tied rakhis to road users who complied

with traffic rules at major intersections including the Chintamani traffic light, Seelampur traffic light in Shahdara Circle, and Majnu Ka Tila check post. During these interactions, commuters were sensitised to wear helmets, use seat belts, follow traffic signals, maintain lane discipline, avoid mobile phone use while driving, and steer clear of drunk driving, according to a senior police officer.

Additional CP (Traffic) Vijayanta Arya said personnel had been deployed at interstate borders witnessing heavy movement in and out of Delhi, as well as at metro stations and markets that typically see high festival footfall. She said motorcycle patrols were operating on key carriageways so that teams could respond quickly whenever a congestion alert came in.

Delhi Metro trains and stations bore the brunt of the festival rush alongside the roads, with several stations reporting unusually heavy passenger volumes through the day as people travelled to reach family before the festi-

val window closed. Traffic personnel and other enforcement teams remained stationed at congestion-prone points through the day, working to ease snarls even as the volume of festival traffic showed little sign of easing by evening.

Earlier, the Delhi Traffic Police issued an advisory in view of Raksha Bandhan celebrations on August 27 and 28, warning of increased pedestrian and vehicular movement around Anand Vihar ISBT, Road No. 56, NH-9 and Vikas Marg. Commuters have been advised to avoid these stretches wherever possible, plan their journeys in advance and allow additional travel time.

The increased road traffic was accompanied by a rush in the Delhi Metro, with several stations and trains witnessing a heavy influx of passengers as people travelled ahead of the festival.

Traffic personnel and other enforcement teams remained deployed at several congestion-prone points to manage the flow of vehicles and ease snarls.

Government plans 61-km elevated corridor along Najafgarh drain

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

To reduce traffic congestion, the Delhi Government plans to hire a private consultant to construct an approximately 61-kilometre elevated corridor along the Najafgarh drain, connecting Wazirabad to North Delhi.

The Government announced the project in February this year. Now the Public Works Department (PWD) plans to hire a consultant to conduct a feasibility study and prepare a project plan. "The stretch is heavily congested due to a mix of slow-moving vehicles and cross movements during peak and non-peak hours, causing heavy traffic. We plan to hire a consultant to conduct a feasibility study before the project starts," a PWD official said.

The project, spanning a total length of 60.77 km, will feature a 5.94-km stretch from Jhatikra Bridge to Chhawla Bridge on the left banks, and 27.415-km stretches along both sides

of the drain from Chhawla to Basaidarpur. Once completed, the corridor will link key arterial roads, including Outer Ring Road, Inner Ring Road, Shivaji Marg, Pankha Road, UER-II (leading to NH-9 Rohtak Road) and Najafgarh Road. Critical junctions will connect to the airport, Dwarka Expressway, and Gurugram Sectors 104 and 110, providing seamless urban-rural connectivity.

"The primary objective of the project is to reduce congestion on major roads and cut travel time and fuel consumption, and lower vehicular emissions. The corridor will provide inter-connectivity with major roads including Outer Ring Road, Inner Ring Road, Shivaji Marg, Pankha Road, UER-II (connecting to NH-9 Rohtak Road), Najafgarh Road and other key routes," the official said, adding that the total cost of the project is estimated at Rs 454 crore.

Under the project, a paved road approximately 61 kilometres long and 7 metres wide will be constructed

along the Najafgarh drain. Separate tracks will be developed for walking, jogging and cycling. A new bridge will be constructed near the Dwarka Metro Depot to facilitate smoother movement.

"Landscaping and tree plantation will be undertaken along the corridor. Where required, new boundary walls will be constructed and damaged walls repaired," the project plan said. According to officials, at a few junctions along the proposed corridor alignment, Delhi Metro rail corridors will be part of the study.

The Najafgarh drain elevated corridor was originally planned around 2012 by the Public Works Department (PWD) as a 14-27 km road to reduce congestion between West and North Delhi. After being put on hold, the project was revived, with the first phase of an elevated corridor officially approved in January 2023 and expanded, with new, major, 57-kilometre, two-lane, service road plans (or expressway) approved in December 2025.



Environmentalists raise Yamuna heath concerns

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The lack of heavy flow in the Yamuna River, with the river not crossing the danger mark even once this year's monsoon season in Delhi, has raised concerns among environmentalists over the ecological health of the river.

At 4 pm on Friday, the Yamuna level was recorded at 202.30 metres at Old Railway Bridge, which serves as a key observation point for tracking the river's flow and potential flood risks.

The warning mark of the city is 204.50 metres, while the danger mark is 205.33 metres, and evacuation of people from low-lying areas along the river starts at 206 metres. Yamuna had reached 204.08 metres on August 8, the highest in the ongoing monsoon season but still below the warning mark. As per the officials, there is no current forecast of a flood in the Yamuna River for the next few days.

"It is quite unusual that the Yamuna has not witnessed any significant flood spell this monsoon. Normally, the river experiences at least one or two low or medium category floods annually. This year, however, peak discharge from Hathnikund Barrage in Haryana has not even



crossed 65,000 cusecs....," said Bhim Singh Rawat, member of the South Asia Network on Dams, Rivers and People (SANDRP).

For Delhi, where the Yamuna receives untreated sewage, industrial effluents and urban runoff along its 22-kilometre stretch, environmentalists say the absence of higher monsoon flows deprives the river of its natural ability to dilute pollutants, transport sediments and recharge floodplains.

Shiv Singh Rawat, former superintending engineer, Haryana Irrigation and Water Resources Department, believes several factors have led to the deficit flow in the Yamuna River. Data from the Hathnikund barrage in Haryana showed that around 40 cumecs of water was being released into the Western Yamuna Canal on Thursday, compared with between 9.9 and 120 cumecs being released into the river stream.

"Below-normal monsoon

rainfall, coupled with climate variability, creates a flow deficit in the Yamuna River. Inadequate river flows mean less dilution and flushing of pollutants, reduced floodplain and groundwater recharge, disrupted sediment transport, degraded habitats and weaker aquatic biodiversity, ultimately undermining the Yamuna's natural ecological functions and resilience," Shiv Rawat further said.

In July 2023, Yamuna reached a historic high of 208.66 metres, well above the danger level. That unprecedented flood event submerged significant portions of Delhi, including key arterial stretches in Civil Lines, Mukherjee Nagar, and ITO, and forced the displacement of several. The flooding was triggered by the heavy discharge of water from the Hathnikund Barrage, which released 3.59 lakh cusecs of water due to intense rainfall in the river's upper catchment areas.

Govt creates CSF to redeem outstanding liabilities

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government has set up a Consolidated Sinking Fund (CSF) to redeem its outstanding liabilities including debt repayment, officials said on Friday.

The fund is to be utilised from current financial year. It will not be utilised for any purpose other than redemption of the outstanding liabilities of the Government, they said. A sinking fund refers to monetary reserve created by a Government or any other agency to dispose of its long term liabilities.

According to an economic survey report, Delhi's outstanding debt by March 2025, stood at ₹30,556.54 crore. It included the non-plan loan received during 2013-14 from Government of India for meeting the outstanding lia-



bilities of Delhi Vidut Board and Delhi Electricity Supply Undertaking, which was ₹3,326.39 crore and Chandrawal Water Treatment Plant amount of ₹447 crore. The outstanding liabilities is defined to comprise both internal debt and public account liabilities of the Government.

The outstanding debt in 2025-26 was around 2.30 per cent of the Gross State Domestic Product (GSDP) of Delhi. Delhi's outstanding liabilities and debt levels remain very low and well under control, historically hovering around 4-5 per cent of its GSDP.

According to a gazette

notification issued recently by Finance department, Delhi government will be able to avail short term special drawing facility from the Reserve Bank of India, against collateral of investment made in the Fund, for meeting temporary cash-flow mismatches, subject to the terms and conditions as fixed by the Bank from time to time. The Delhi Government will make "conscious efforts" for building up the CSF corpus to 5 per cent of the outstanding liabilities within a span of five years.

There is no ceiling on contributions to the Fund in terms of number of times it is done in an year. The Government may invest in the Fund from the general revenue at any time or from other sources such as disinvestment proceeds, at its discretion, said the notification.

6 juveniles held for stabbing man, snatching phone in southeast Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Six juveniles have been apprehended for allegedly stabbing a 26-year-old man and snatching his mobile phone in southeast Delhi's Okhla area, police said on Friday. The incident occurred around 8.30 pm on Wednesday near Shyam Nagar in Okhla Phase-3, according to police.

The victim, identified as

Subrata Manna, was walking through a poorly lit pathway while returning from Harkesh Nagar when he was intercepted by a group of assailants armed with knives, police said. The assailants allegedly attacked Manna and stabbed him multiple times before fleeing with his mobile phone. He was rushed to the AIIMS Trauma Centre for treatment, according to police.

A case was registered at



the Okhla Industrial Area police station following the incident. During the investigation, police used local intel-

ligence, field verification and other leads to identify six juveniles allegedly involved in the crime. All six were subsequently apprehended, police said. The stolen mobile phone was recovered, along with two knives allegedly used in the attack.

Police said further investigation is underway to determine whether the juveniles were involved in any other similar incidents in the area.

The case has once again drawn attention to instances of juvenile involvement in violent street crime in the capital, with police increasingly relying on local intelligence networks to trace young offenders operating in groups.

The investigation remains ongoing, with police continuing to examine the broader pattern of activity linked to the group before deciding on further course of action.

THIEVES FOLLOW MAN FROM EATERY, OPEN FIRE TO ROB GOLD CHAIN

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two men followed a target from an eatery to the Rani Jhansi Flyover, where they opened fire and brandished a knife at him and his companion to snatch a gold chain, police said on Friday.

The accused Javed alias Pauva, 38, a parole jumper, and Deepanshu alias Deepu, 25, chased the victims for about 50 metres and fired another shot before fleeing towards Filmistan in north Delhi. Police said the victims escaped unhurt in the incident, which happened around 3:45 pm on Thursday when they were travelling towards their hotel on a scooter.

After their arrest, the accused allegedly told police they saw the victim wearing a gold chain while eating near Fateh Kachori and decided to target him. They subsequently followed him on the scooter before attempting to rob him at the flyover.



Representational Image

Police said two men riding a scooter approached them and signalled them to stop. As the complainant attempted to park his scooter, one of the accused allegedly pulled out a pistol, cocked it and fired at him and his companion, while the other charged at them with a button-operated knife. After the unsuccessful attempt, they fled from the scene, police said.

A case was registered under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act at the Civil Lines police station. Police said investigators reviewed the CCTV footage of the route taken by the accused and obtained clear images of their faces. The Facial Recognition System, technical surveillance and local intelligence helped identify the accused. Police said they first apprehended Deepanshu from Sadar Bazar following a tip-off. Based on information obtained during his interrogation, a police team travelled to Bhiwadi and arrested Javed.

Police said they recovered two pistols, including the one allegedly used in the crime, two live cartridges, a knife and the scooter used in the offence.

IN FOCUS



A woman ties a Rakhi to a passenger boarded on a bus in Nadia

PTI

UP CM Yogi orders strict monitoring of swine flu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Friday directed the health department and district magistrates to closely monitor the swine flu situation and ensure adequate medical arrangements at hospitals, appealing to people not to panic and seek timely testing and treatment.

The chief minister directed officials to regularly review swine flu cases in the state and ensure there is no negligence at any level, the state government said in a statement.

He ordered hospitals to keep isolation wards, essential medicines, testing kits and treatment facilities



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath takes a selfie with school students during Snehbandhan programme to celebrate Raksha Bandhan festival, at his official residence in Lucknow

PTI

available so that patients could receive immediate care when required, it stated. Adityanath also

directed district magistrates and health officials to maintain vigilance in respective districts and regularly

review healthcare arrangements."Any change in the swine flu situation should be communicated to the highest level in the government immediately," the statement said, quoting the chief minister.

Adityanath appealed to people not to ignore possible symptoms of swine flu, also asserting there was no need to panic.

"If symptoms appear, seek medical advice in time and get the necessary tests done," he said, according to the statement. He said timely testing and treatment could help prevent serious effects of the disease and directed officials to ensure adequate health services and facilities are available.

BJP is India's biggest crisis, has no agenda beyond hate: Akhilesh



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Etawah

Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav on Friday described the BJP as the "biggest crisis" facing the country and alleged that the ruling party had no agenda other than spreading hatred.

Yadav, who was in his native village Saifai in Etawah district on the occasion of Raksha Bandhan, made the remarks while interacting with the media.

"There is only one crisis in the country, and that is the BJP. The BJP itself is the biggest crisis. If the BJP goes, the crisis will go," he said.

The former Uttar Pradesh chief minister alleged that the BJP had no work apart from "spreading hatred" and accused it of "selling" the legacy of socialist leader Jayaprakash Narayan.

He said the BJP, when it was formed, had displayed a photograph of Narayan in an attempt to project itself as a

socialist party, but had now "sold" the Jayaprakash Narayan International Convention Centre (JPNIC).

"Nobody is even willing to buy the BJP; otherwise, the BJP would have sold itself," Yadav said sarcastically.

On inflation, the SP chief alleged that the government was allowing prices of essential commodities and fuel to rise to benefit industrialists.

"Where sugar is concerned, sugar has become expensive. The government is mixing ethanol in petrol. There is a law governing adulteration; legally, you cannot adulterate. But under a well-thought-out strategy, to benefit certain people and to obtain election donations, the government has given industrialists a free hand to make profits," he alleged.

Yadav claimed that sugar, diesel and petrol were being sold at higher prices to enable companies to make profits, and said inflation was rising because of the government's policies.

Delhi BJP reshuffles OBC, Kisan Morcha units, names new district chiefs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi BJP has announced fresh organisational appointments to its OBC Morcha and Kisan Morcha, naming new office-bearers and district presidents for both wings within a span of two days this week.

The appointments were made with the approval of Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra and following consultations with the party's senior leadership, according to letters issued by the two frontal organisations.

In the first round of appointments, dated August 26, OBC Morcha state presi-



dent Santosh Pal named eight vice presidents for the Delhi unit: Darshan Singh Verma, Lokesh Nambardar, Ram Naresh Ahirwal, Shyam Kumar Sen, Mahesh Awana, Manjeet Beniwal, Himanshu

Yadav and Satish Lohiya. Ram Khiladi Yadav, Akash Jeldar and Mohit Nagar were appointed general secretaries of the OBC Morcha, while Brijesh Jaiswal was named treasurer, according to the appointment letter.

Eight leaders were also named as ministers within the Morcha, including Ajay Saini, Rambir Sain, Anita Chaudhary, Kamlesh Yadav, Naresh Chaudhary, Priyanka Singh, Gaurav Baghel and Rohit Sahrawat. Akhilesh Kumar was appointed office secretary. The OBC Morcha also announced four spokespersons, Varun Saini, Satish alias Bittu, S.S. Gola and Kapil Nagar, along with

Mohit Verma as media head, Manish Yadav as social media head and Akash Verma as IT head. In a separate list issued the same day, the OBC Morcha named district presidents for 14 districts across Delhi, including Lokesh Chandela for Keshav Puram, Sanjay Gehlot for Chandni Chowk, Nitin Chaudhary for North East, Sompal Panchal for New Shahdara, Gaurav Dedha for Mayur Vihar, and Manoj Chaudhary for Shahdara.

Other district presidents named include Ashwani Yadav for New Delhi, Rishi Tanwar for Karol Bagh, Ashok Verma for North West, Umesh Vishwakarma for

Outer Delhi, Neeraj Gupta for West Delhi, Deepak Dagar for Najafgarh, Balraj Singh Chaudhary for Mehrauli and Pushpendra Rathore for South Delhi. Two days later, on August 28, the Kisan Morcha's state president Devendra Solanki announced a similar set of appointments for the party's farmer-focused wing. Pramod Chaudhary, Urmila Chaudhary, Arun Chaudhary, Satpal Malik, Sandeep Dedha, Sunil Chauhan, Devendra Banke Pahalan and Arvind Nagar were named vice presidents of the Kisan Morcha. Rajpal Rana, Anup Chaudhary and Jitendra Khatri were appointed

general secretaries, while Rahul Mathur was named treasurer. The Kisan Morcha also announced eight ministers, including Sunny Dedha, Dr Ravindra Dabas, Anmol Rana, Manvendra Singh, Dr Prateek Chaudhary, Anand Dahiya, Sumit Rana and Munesh Chauhan, with Bhupendra Singh appointed office secretary.

Vinod Jayas was named chief spokesperson of the Kisan Morcha, with Manoj Tyagi, Sunil Shyoran and Abhay Kalra appointed as spokespersons. Narayan Pratap Singh was named media head, Devvrat Kumar as social media head and Jatin Khari as IT head.

Jharkhand CID arrests 4 people who cracked JSSC-CGL in exam irregularity case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

The Jharkhand Police's Criminal Investigation Department on Friday arrested four successful candidates of the JSSC-CGL examination held in 2024 as part of its probe into alleged irregular-



ities in the recruitment test. The State probe agency arrested two accused in connection with the case a day earlier. It has also nabbed the key accused, Abhay Tiwari, his wife and brother in late July and early August. The Jharkhand Government had earlier announced the cancel-

lation of a host of recruitment tests, including the JSSC-CGL-2023 conducted on September 21 and 22, 2024, to quell a protest by job aspirants against alleged exam irregularities. However, the Jharkhand High Court put a stay on the Government's decision to cancel certain

exams, including the JSSC-CGL-2023, based on a plea by successful candidates who fear job loss.

A Special Investigation Team of the Jharkhand CID is probing the alleged irregularities in the JSSC-CGL exam. In a statement on Friday, the CID said, "In connection with

alleged irregularities in the Jharkhand Graduate Level Combined Competitive Examination-2023 conducted by the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission, four successful candidates of the JSSC-CGL examination have been arrested." They have been identified as Dhanbad

district residents Deepak Kumar, Vijay Kumar Tiwari, Anand Kumar Singh, and Umesh Kumar Rai, currently staying in Bokaro.

On July 22, the CID arrested Abhay Tiwari, then posted as a block supply officer in Poriyhat in Godda district, in connection with the probe.

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579 dead in Nepal, 320 Indians missing

At the same time, 21 Tamil Nadu pilgrims rescued from flood-hit areas arrived in New Delhi, while 63 Indian nationals associated with the Trishuli-I hydropower project were also rescued. Another group of Indian nationals stranded on the Chinese side of the border was able to cross into Nepal safely.

The scale of the disaster has become clearer as rescue teams have gained access to affected areas. According to the latest government figures, 538 bodies had been recovered by Friday. Search teams are continuing to work through mud, debris and damaged structures in an effort to locate people still missing.

Officials are facing major challenges in determining the final casualty figure because several affected areas are remote and difficult to reach. Communication problems have also complicated efforts to establish the whereabouts of people reported missing.

The disaster followed a major ice and rock collapse in the high Himalayan region close to the Nepal-China border. A huge quantity of ice, rock and sediment entered the Lhende Khola river system, generating a powerful flow that moved downstream towards the Bhote Koshi corridor. The surge carried enormous amounts of debris, damaging infrastructure and threatening communities along the river.

The sudden event initially prompted speculation about an earthquake. However, subsequent assessments indicated that seismic activity recorded in the area was associated with the landslide rather than being the primary cause of the disaster.

Rescue efforts are being carried out amid concerns that the danger may not yet be over. A large accumulation of water and debris has created a barrier lake in the river system, raising fears that a breach could produce another sudden flood downstream.

Authorities are monitoring the situation closely and assessing the stability of the blockage. Developments in Tibet are also being watched because additional water entering the already disrupted river system could increase the danger. The potential for another flood surge has added to the difficulties facing rescue teams working in already damaged areas. Nepal has mobilised personnel from its Army, Armed Police Force and Nepal Police to conduct search, rescue and relief operations. Helicopters have been deployed to evacuate stranded people and transport essential supplies to communities cut off by damaged roads and bridges. Food, medicines and other relief material are being delivered to areas that remain inaccessible by road. Private helicopters have also joined the relief effort as authorities attempt to reach people trapped in remote locations. India has stepped up humanitarian assistance to Nepal alongside efforts to locate its nationals. More than 47 tonnes

of emergency relief supplies have been sent to the flood-hit country, with additional assistance being prepared.

The MEA is coordinating with Nepalese authorities and Indian state governments as information about missing nationals is gathered and verified. The immediate focus remains on finding those still untraceable, evacuating stranded people and providing emergency assistance to communities affected by the floods.

With 538 bodies recovered and 320 Indian nationals still untraceable, the disaster has emerged as a major humanitarian crisis in the region. Rescue operations are expected to continue as teams search through the affected river valleys and authorities monitor the risk of further flooding.

Sonia memoir sparks fresh battle over...

He claimed that pressure was put on Penguin India "to remove sections on Modi, RSS and those related to the occupation of Indian territory by China during the Modi regime".

Senior party leader and former Madhya Pradesh chief minister Kamal Nath also said the publisher's "refusal" to publish the autobiography is a matter of grave concern.

"Will the publisher decide what a senior figure like Mrs. Gandhi will write and what she will not? The question also arises whether the publisher is saying this on its own or if there is pressure from someone on it?" Nath said in his post on X in Hindi. Congress' deputy leader in Lok Sabha Gaurav Gogoi slammed Penguin India's statement on the issue as "weak".

"Such a weak statement. Penguin India is more than happy to publish 'Exam Warriors' and several books on RSS. No doubt there are those in the BJP government who have now become afraid of a book being being read by the people of India," Gogoi said on social media.

The Seva Dal, on its official handle, took a swipe at Penguin India, posting, "Paltu Penguin."

The Indian Youth Congress said, "Dear SOLD Penguin, nobody asked whether you were 'keen'. Tell us what changes you wanted, and why. The rest is corporate grammar."

PRHI is the Indian subsidiary/operating company of Penguin Random House (PRH), the global publishing group.

India seals Javelin deal as US defence...

The system is produced by the Javelin joint Venture, a partnership between RTX and Lockheed Martin. The shoulder-fired system features an automatic guidance mechanism that allows the missile to track its target after launch, enabling the oper-

ator to take cover and avoid counter fire.

The procurement of Javelin missiles will be Government-to-Government deal through the Foreign Military Sales (FMS) route wherein the US Government stands guarantee for all the contractual obligations. However, it is not immediately known the number of Javelin anti-tank guided missile systems India is procuring or the overall cost of the procurement.

The Indian army has signed a Letter of Offer and Acceptance (LOA) for the purchase of the Javelin missiles under emergency procurement. The development comes months after Defence Minister Rajnath Singh and his US counterpart Pete Hegseth signed a 10-year framework to deepen bilateral defence relations.

The latest deal comes amid India's expanding procurement of US defence equipment. In November 2025, the US State Department approved a potential \$93 million sale to India covering up to 100 Javelin systems and 216 Excalibur guided artillery projectiles.

The United States and India signed a framework for a major defence partnership last year in October, aimed at strengthening interoperability across land, sea, air, space, and cyberspace. India has also acquired several US-made defence platforms, including Apache and Chinook helicopters, C-17 and C-130J transport aircraft, P-8I maritime patrol aircraft and M777 howitzers.

RSS mouthpiece links civil society...

Their idea of "penetrating" the bureaucracy, policy machinery, legal system, academia, media and NGO is part of the "revolutionary strategy", he adds. "The National Advisory Council of the Sonia Gandhi-led UPA government was a classic takeover of the *Dimagi* Naxals of governance," the editorial adds.

"As PM Modi used the term *Dimagi* Naxals, some people got rattled and started questioning the term as anti-intellectual, while usual suspects turned it into a badge of honour by turning it into another mode of resistance in the form of *Dimagi* Naxal Party," Ketkar wrote in an apparent reference to senior Congress leader P Chidambaram. A day after the PM's address, Chidambaram took a swipe at Modi over his *Dimagi* Naxals remark, and said in a social media post "I am proud to be a dimagi naxal."

Ketkar claims understanding the dangers posed by *dimagi* Naxals and collaborating with agencies and security forces to identify and expose them is "our national duty". He said Prime Minister Modi, in his Independence Day speech, tried to "sensitise" the citizens about this duty. "Decode, identify and expose *Dimagi* Naxals who want to fool the masses by exploiting their sentiments and genuine concerns; they cannot be the real change-makers but are dangerous agents of violent authoritarianism where decisions will be taken on the roads and through

resistance without any democratic participation," he said. "As the armed rebellion has failed miserably, the *Dimagi* variant has taken charge," Ketkar added.

couple from Delhi held in spy case

The SIM card operation was not a single event.

Police claim Sahil was also asked to find and recruit people to check out cantonment areas across different parts of India and collect details about army personnel with court-martial cases pending before tribunals. Investigators say Sameera played a key role in arranging and sending the SIM cards.

Officials said a forensic check of Sahil's phone found chats with Pakistani contacts, supporting the story of social-media recruitment. Police describe Sahil's background as ordinary until the alleged foreign contact. He graduated from IGNOU, worked with a lawyer, and became unemployed after leaving that job in June 2025. His father is a car mechanic. Sameera finished her graduation through correspondence and worked at a call centre.

Police say the larger network extends from Delhi to Karachi and Islamabad, using local recruits mostly for logistics rather than gathering top-level intelligence. The Special Cell has not revealed the names of the Pakistani handlers or the exact groups the accounts tried to reach. Sahil's questioning led to Sameera's arrest. Both are still in custody as investigators check phones, money trails, and anyone else Sahil may have tried to recruit for reconnaissance.

Delhi Police say these arrests have broken up one logistics cell within a larger suspected network that used social media to make first contact and commercial couriers to move items.

New Delhi scheme targets loneliness with...

The amount will be released in two equal half-yearly installments. The assistance will be provided to centres run for senior citizens aged 60 years and above. Operators will have to prioritise providing all the arrangements and facilities mentioned above at their centres. Such centres must be located in Delhi and operate from community spaces.

The scheme may also cover centres operating through RWAs, CGHS and community spaces such as chaupals. The centres will be established in Delhi Urban Shelter Improvement Board rain baseras night shelters and Municipal Corporation of Delhi community halls across the city. In areas lacking indoor facilities, they will be set up in parks and traditional 'choupals', ensuring wider accessibility.

"The objective of the Vayo Anand scheme is to provide senior citizens with a safe and con-

venient place close to their homes where they can spend time with people of their age group, participate in recreational and health-related activities, stay away from loneliness and lead an active social life. The government is committed to strengthening such arrangements in the interest of senior citizens so that they can have a better environment for a dignified and healthy life," it said.

Nepal braces for second flood wave as death...

"Information has been received that the water dam on the Tibetan side has burst again," Nepal Police said in a post on X.

However, the Nepal government clarified there was no information about any dam bursting. Government spokesperson and Education Minister Sasmita Pokharel said this while speaking to journalists following Friday's Cabinet meeting, according to the Onlinekhabar news portal. "There is no information that a dam has burst anywhere. Since glaciers have broken off, water mixed with mud has overflowed in several places," Pokharel said. "No major immediate risk has been observed, but it is necessary to remain alert."

Pokharel said the government was maintaining continuous communication with the Chinese government through the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and had been informed that there was no major risk. Chinese authorities have also said water flow in the Bhotekoshi River area of Nepal's Rasuwa district has increased, but maintained that a lake formed upstream was stable and had not burst, the Rising Nepal Daily newspaper reported. According to officials at Nepal's Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Chinese side said the increase in water flow in the upper reaches was due to an avalanche, but the lake formed after the river was blocked had not burst, the report said.

The Chinese side said the size of the lake was increasing, and water was continuously overflowing, but there had been no major outburst or rupture of the lake. It said there was no immediate risk of major flooding and that the situation was being continuously monitored, according to the report.

On Thursday, Nepal's Department of Hydrology and Meteorology had warned of a fresh flood risk downstream of the Bhote Koshi River following the formation of a new barrier lake near the Nepal-China border. Earlier, Chinese authorities had informed Nepal that around 2 million cubic metres of water had accumulated in the lake, with another 3 million cubic metres potentially entering it over three days, raising concerns about a possible breach.

The lake had formed near the confluence of the Chhochen Khola and Purepu Tsangpo rivers, which originate in Tibet and flow into Nepal as part of the Bhote Koshi river system.

Govt sets up exclusive NIA courts in 3 states to fast-track terror trials

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Union Government has set up three new exclusive National Investigation Agency (NIA) special courts in Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Bihar to expedite trials in anti-terror cases handled by the agency.

Exercising its powers under Section 11 of the National Investigation Agency Act, 2008, and after consultations with the Chief Justices of the High Courts of Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan, and Patna, the Union Government has designated special courts in Visakhapatnam, Jaipur, and Patna as exclusive NIA courts.

According to a gazette notification from the Ministry of Home Affairs, these courts will handle only Scheduled Offences investigated by the NIA. They will have statewide authority for cases under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA).

This move comes after months of Supreme Court oversight of delays in NIA and UAPA trials. On December 16, 2025, the Centre told the Supreme Court it would set up a dedicated NIA court in every State and Union Territory, and more than one court where over 10 anti-terror cases were pending, to speed up trials.

In February 2026, the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) submitted a status report to the Supreme Court, suggesting that exclusive special courts be established in States with 10 or more NIA cases awaiting trial.

The report said the Centre would provide a one-time grant of Rs 1 crore for initial



expenses and Rs 1 crore each year for ongoing costs for each court. This funding is for things like renovating infrastructure, purchasing IT equipment and vehicles, and paying staff salaries.

An Office Memorandum from January 7, 2026, set the same spending limits and made it clear that the Centre would not pay for land or new buildings. States were told to use an existing court-room instead.

The difference between a designated special court and an exclusive court has been a key issue in the case. India already has many courts under the NIA Act, but most of them also handle other criminal cases. The Supreme Court has said that exclusive courts should hear NIA cases every day and only take up other matters when there are no NIA cases to handle.

In March 2026, the Court filed its own petition to create these exclusive courts. It later ordered that if there

are more than 15 pending trials, there should be at least two exclusive courts, and if there are more than 25, there should be at least three.

By late July, the Union told the Court that 14 exclusive NIA courts had been set up in nine States, including Bihar, Gujarat, Jharkhand, Maharashtra, Assam, and Punjab. Andhra Pradesh and Rajasthan still needed more action. Andhra Pradesh already had special courts in Vijayawada and Visakhapatnam. In July, its Cabinet approved a dedicated NIA court in Visakhapatnam with statewide authority after the High Court noticed many pending cases there. Bihar has had an exclusive court in Patna since January 2026 and is considering adding another. Rajasthan, with about 10 pending NIA trials, had not yet started an exclusive court.

The latest notifications

address this gap for the three States. Officials say that exclusive benches should help shorten the long periods undertrials spend in jail, a practice often criticised by the courts.

Judges have pointed out that accused people should not be kept in custody for too long just because crowded court schedules delay their trials.

The Court has also told States to try to finish an NIA trial in about a month by holding continuous hearings and using dedicated special public prosecutors. The financial support and the need for High Court consultation are meant to make sure the courts actually work, not just exist on paper. The new benches in Jaipur, Patna and Visakhapatnam begin day-to-day hearings without delay. They will now be monitored as part of the Supreme Court's ongoing review of exclusive special courts nationwide.

Adhikari holds Vande Mataram rally outside JU, says campus needs to be mended

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

Days after the violent clashes between the supporters of the ABVP and Left-wing student groups inside the elite Jadavpur University campus, Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Friday held a massive Vande Mataram rally outside the campus — otherwise considered a strong Left bastion — from where he gave a call to “mend JU as the JNU and Osmania University were corrected.”

Adhikari was speaking at an “apolitical” programme where Vande Mataram was sung by ten thousand people.

Launching a scathing attack against the Leftist forces for raising “Azadi” slogans, he said, “this kind of anti-national slogans must stop in the education campus. “I am hurt when the slogans of Azadi are raised on the streets of Kolkata... What is Azadi? The country achieved Independence a long time back... For Azadi, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose, Khudiram Bose, Bhagat Singh and many others laid down their lives... after that Azadi (freedom) what kind of Azadi these people are talking about... the only Azadi that we need now is the Azadi of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir and



West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari holds a national tri-colour flag during a rally to pay tributes to 150 years of Vande Mataram at Jadavpur in Kolkata on Friday

PTI

that we will be achieved soon.”

Alleging that “slogans like Kashmir mange Azadi or those supporting slain Maoist leader Kishenji were regularly raised from the campuses”, he said, “TMC supported these elements to prosper... but not

anymore... those days are gone... we will not allow such slogans inside the campus.”

He said, often slogans like “Red Salute Kishenji” is written on the walls of Jadavpur University. What does a section of the new generation want? Who is this Kishenji? He never believed in the Indian Constitution.”

Reminding that the educational campus like Jadavpur University was a place of excellence where education should be the only concern of the students, he asked whether the Left students' wings demanded freedom to use “cannabis, heroin and drugs”, warning “now drones would be flown inside the campus” to find out who all were taking drugs.

Asking why the Left would not take out rallies when CRPF jawans were brutally killed in Jammu and Kashmir or why Hindus were slain in Pahalgaon because of their identities. “When CRPF jawans were killed or when Hindus were shot dead by ascertaining their identities, why do these Left-wing people not take out rallies... and why do they take out rallies only during the India-Pakistan war, when India would be about to demolish the enemy?” he asked.

Parivartan 2.0 in Bengal soon after Delhi crumbles: Mamata

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

Delhi was crumbling and will soon fall, triggering in turn a wave and a second Parivartan (change) in Bengal for which the Trinamool Congress workers should remain prepared so that they can lap up the opportunity, TMC chief Mamata Banerjee on Friday said, launching a scathing attack on the BJP

“Delhi will soon crumble”, and Bengal would follow suit, she thundered from a Trinamool Congress Chatra Parishad foundation day rally.

Alleging that Bengal would not have gone into the hands of the saffron outfit had the BJP led Centre not manipulated the Election Commission



of India to its advantage the former State Chief Minister told a TMC rally, “already hundred days of this Government has passed and they have incurred enough unpopularity ... they are not going to stay in power for long ... because they have

hurt the people ... the TMC will have to remain prepared for that time ... we will definitely revive and bounce back with huge force.”

The TMC supreme's diatribe came a day after the Kolkata Police arrested 13 TMC workers and lodged FIRs

against Abhishek Banerjee and Derek O' Brien hours following Thursday's ruckus at Abhishek's party office when the TMC MPs and party men allegedly tried to prevent police personnel from pulling down some “illegal” hoardings in the office area.

Launching a no-holds-barred attack on the saffron outfit she said “BJP captured the power by theft... they used the ECI and looted votes through the SIR... they used the Commission and a monstrous police force to hijack the last Assembly elections... but don't worry... be on the streets and carry on your resistance... a second Parivartan is coming in Bengal... let Delhi fall and it will fall soon”.

Resignation will come, but accountability must come first: NC MP Ruhullah



MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

National Conference Lok Sabha MP from Srinagar Aga Syed Ruhullah Mehdi has once again questioned Dr Farooq Abdullah's demand for his resignation. In his latest letter addressed to the party President, Ruhullah recalled that Abdullah had served as Chief Minister when the Jammu and Kashmir Assembly passed the Autonomy Resolution.

“Why, then, has the mere mention of constitutional guarantees for Jammu-Kashmir now become so offensive that you felt compelled to publicly demand my resignation?” he asked, adding, “What has changed, the aspirations of our people, or the JKNC's willingness to stand up for them?”

Referring to Farooq Abdullah's reported statement that “You want 370, but you beg from Delhi,” Ruhullah said the uncomfortable truth was that even demands for Article 370 and statehood were being presented before Delhi. He questioned why the National Conference's position had effectively become no different from that of the BJP if statehood was accepted as the outer limit of Jammu and Kashmir's political aspirations.

The Srinagar MP argued that treating statehood as the ultimate political goal risks legitimising and normalising the constitutional changes of August 2019, while potentially surrendering constitutional protections which, he said, are important given Jammu and Kashmir's unique geopolitical situation, culture, traditions and fragile environment.

Ruhullah said there were “many more questions” but that he would await Farooq

Abdullah's response, as would the people of Jammu and Kashmir, who, he said, had a right to know what the National Conference truly stands for. On the resignation issue, Ruhullah said, “Rest assured, the resignation will come. It would have come even without you asking, but before that must come accountability.”

Addressing Farooq Abdullah's reported remarks questioning who he was before joining the National Conference, Ruhullah said he was the “inheritor of a long tradition of martyrdom” and the son of a martyr.

He further said that Farooq Abdullah had personally invited him to join the National Conference, adding that not many people knew this but Abdullah did.

Referring to Farooq Abdullah's August 25 statement, “How long will you be a slave? You have to stand on your feet sometimes. When will you stand?” Ruhullah said the remarks resonated with the frustration of people of Jammu and Kashmir who, according to him, are often expected to adopt a posture of supplication before the BJP while seeking what they consider rightfully theirs.

Ruhullah said he was compelled to ask why his own demand for constitutional guarantees for Jammu and Kashmir should be objected to if Farooq Abdullah's remarks were not merely “hollow posturing” for public consumption.

Ruhullah also questioned the National Conference's 2024 Assembly election manifesto, which had promised restoration of Article 370, asking why the party included the issue in its manifesto despite knowing that the BJP was in power at the Centre.

Cheetah Nirwa found safe after 21 days, returns to Kuno enclosure as collar failed

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

Female cheetah Nirwa, brought to Kuno National Park from South Africa, has been found safe nearly 21 days after she went missing from the park. Her satellite collar had stopped transmitting signals, leaving forest officials without a confirmed location during the monsoon.

After an extended search operation, the Kuno team finally traced Nirwa and safely brought her back to an enclosure. Her recovery has come as a major relief for officials associated with the cheetah reintroduction



project. Kuno National Park Field Director Uttam Kumar Sharma shared the development on X while highlighting the achievement of the cheetah project. He said

the search continued despite the absence of signals from Nirwa's collar.

For nearly 21 days, the team had been unable to obtain reliable information

Blast in Himachal traced to pipeline from Punjab

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

A device exploded near the Nalagarh police station on New Year's morning, leaving a two-foot crater and scattering glass up to 40 metres away, but no one was killed. Eight months later, investigators have found a complicated network that includes foreign handlers, the Punjab-based Babbar Khalsa International group, a drug trafficking route, and young men acting as couriers.

The explosion happened around 9.40 am on January 1, 2026, near the outer wall next to the investigating officer's room at the Solan district station. The blast damaged windows in nearby buildings, including an Army canteen. Himachal Police first registered FIR No. 02/2026. Later, the National Investigation Agency took over and, on May 8, re-registered the case as RC-27/2026/NIA/DLI under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Explosive Substances Act, and the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act.

Investigators soon rejected the first version of events. Within a day, Babbar Khalsa International and the Punjab Sovereignty Alliance claimed responsibility for the attack. In their statement, they claimed the motive was the trafficking of synthetic drugs from the Baddi-Nalagarh area into Punjab. They named overseas figures, including Gopi Nawanshahria, as plan-



ners and threatened more attacks on police vehicles and headquarters.

Punjab Police said the drug-related motive was just a cover, pointing out that the method matched earlier attacks on police stations in Punjab, where foreign handlers paid young people to carry out the attacks. They said ideology was only a front and that money was the real reason. The first major lead did not come from Nalagarh CCTV, which had limited coverage, but from an NDPS case at Rahon police station in Shaheed Bhagat Singh Nagar.

On January 29, Punjab Police arrested Shamsher Singh, also known as Sheru and Kamal, and Pardeep Singh, also known as Deepu, both from Rahon, and found an unused IED. On December 31, 2025, the two men and two others took an IED from Punjab to Himachal. Police said this device was used the next morning. The two men acted on orders from Shushant Chopra, who is close to

Gurpreet Singh, also known as Gopi Nawanshahria, and BKI member Harwinder Singh Rinda.

On February 22, Counter Intelligence teams in Jalandhar and SAS Nagar arrested Mahavir, also known as Kaka, and Manpreet, also known as Mani, both from SBS Nagar. They were found with a 9 mm Glock and four live cartridges. Punjab DGP Gaurav Yadav said they had received RDX-based IEDs and hand grenades from foreign masterminds. Gopi Nawanshahria, Jassi Kulam, and Shushant Chopra.

Six others involved in moving the equipment had already been arrested. Punjab Police said the group was dismantled. Investigators are focusing on three main findings: The blast was not planned in Himachal, the equipment was brought across the state border the night before, and the operation was directed from abroad. The team on the ground worked from Punjab, and the first lead came from a drugs case.

about her location.

The malfunctioning collar had made monitoring Nirwa particularly challenging. Her presence in the forest remained uncertain during the monsoon, when changing weather conditions and dense vegetation can make tracking wildlife more difficult. The team continued its efforts and eventually succeeded in tracing her location and bringing her back safely.

Nirwa's prolonged disappearance and the failure of her collar had also triggered concerns outside the park. Wildlife worker Ajay Dubey had submitted a written complaint to the Union

Minister of State for Environment and Forests and the Member Secretary of the National Tiger Conservation Authority (NTCA), seeking a high-level inquiry into the matter and an examination of the technical failure of the collar.

The complaint also raised the deaths of sniffer dogs Ilu and Ruby in Kuno and sought an inquiry into alleged management lapses and action against those found responsible. It further called for an independent investigation into reported wildlife poaching cases in the park.

With Nirwa now safely located and returned to the enclosure, the development

Drone drops used to push guns, drugs into Punjab

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/ Chandigarh

Punjab Police have busted two smuggling networks that had been supplying weapons and narcotics into the state and were using drones to transport their cargo across the international border. Six people have now been arrested, and 2.920 kg of heroin together with eight high-end pistols have been seized.

Gaurav Yadav, the Director General of Police (DGP), stated that the State Special Operations Cell (SSOC), Amritsar, and the Counter Intelligence (CI) unit in Amritsar conducted the two operations independently. “As a result of a breakthrough, the State Special Operations Cell (SSOC), Amritsar and Counter Intelligence (CI), Amritsar, carried out two separate operations during which they busted smuggling networks involving weapons and narcotics, arrested six suspects, and seized 2.920 kg of heroin together with eight high-end pistols,” he posted on X.

As the DGP has stated, the main conclusion of the initial investigation concerns the method of delivery; it is alleged that the accused were involved in a cross-border pipeline that received both arms and heroin by drone and then got ready to distribute the cargo amongst the criminal elements in



Punjab. First Information Reports (FIRs) have separately been filed at the SSOC police station in Amritsar.

The importance of that point goes beyond the actual figures. A drone doesn't require a gap in the fence or a crossing of a river to be delivered by a courier; it is capable of carrying a small cargo, such as pistols packed with magazines or heroin compressed into small parcels, and can drop it in the fields or in areas beside rivers on the Indian side. After it has been delivered to the ground, the cargo can be picked up, divided up and transported inland before the security forces arrive.

According to the police, the most recent modules adhered to that sequence: they received the drop, took custody of the weapons and the narcotics, and then intro-

duced them into the state's criminal market. The fact that nearly three kilograms of heroin and eight pistols have been recovered from the same series of operations indicates that the drones were not used for a single type of commodity; arms and drugs were using the same air route.

The investigators are currently working on reconstructing the corridor by starting at both ends. The forward linkages would show who was waiting for the pistols and the heroin in Punjab, while the backward linkages would reveal who packed the drones, who flew them, and who directed the drops from over the border.

DGP Yadav stated that the investigation targets everyone connected to the network, not just the six already in custody.



■ States Focus ■



GOVT APPOINTS 2 DIRECTORS, JOINT DIRECTOR TO NTA

The Centre has appointed two directors and a joint director to the National Testing Agency (NTA), which has been facing flak for issues related to the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) paper leak, among other concerns.

Ravi Kumar Singh (Indian Police Service officer) and Prasanna Venkatesh V, an Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer, have been appointed as directors in the NTA, according to separate orders dated August 27, issued by the personnel ministry.

Amit Samdariya, a 2016 batch Indian Revenue Service (Customs and Indirect Taxes) officer, has been selected for appointment as joint director in the NTA, an order issued by the personnel ministry said. (PNS)



PM MODI CONDOLES DEMISE OF NORWAY'S KING HARALD V

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday condoled the death of Norway's King Harald V and said he was deeply touched by his warmth and profound sense of service to his nation. King Harald V, who was Europe's oldest monarch, has died. He was 89. "Deeply saddened by the passing of His Majesty King Harald V of the Kingdom of Norway. I fondly recall meeting His Majesty during my visit to Norway earlier this year and was deeply touched by his warmth and profound sense of service to his nation. My heartfelt condolences to the Royal Family and the people of Norway," Modi said in a post on social media. (PNS)

PM pays tributes to Ayyankali, Sree Narayana Guru on birth anniversaries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi paid tributes to Kerala's renowned social reformers Mahatma Ayyankali and Sree Narayana Guru on their birth anniversaries on Friday, saying they are remembered as great pioneers of social justice.

The prime minister said Mahatma Ayyankali's life gives strength to all those working for social empowerment and Sree Narayana Guru's thoughts gave strength to countless people. Kerala witnessed various programmes to mark the 163rd birth anniversary of Mahatma Ayyankali and 170th birth anniversary of Sree Narayana Guru on Friday.

"Paying homage to Mahatma Ayyankali on his birth anniversary! He is remembered as a great pioneer of social justice. His efforts to secure educational



opportunities for the marginalised, improve the lives of agricultural workers and serve the poor remain very inspiring. His life gives strength to all those working for social empowerment," Modi said in a social media post.

Paying homage to Sree Narayana Guru, the prime minister said he was a towering social reformer, spiritual leader and thinker, and he devoted his life to building a society rooted in dignity and compassion. "His thoughts gave

EAM receives 21 Tamil Nadu pilgrims rescued from Nepal

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

External Affairs Minister (EAM) S Jaishankar on Friday received 21 pilgrims from Tamil Nadu who were rescued from devastating floods in Nepal, even as the Indian Government continued efforts to establish contact with hundreds of Indians still stranded in the neighbouring country.

In a post on X, Jaishankar said he was moved after hearing the pilgrims recount their experiences and thanked the Nepal Government and the Nepali Army for their rescue efforts.

"Received a group of 21 pilgrims from Tamil Nadu who were rescued from the floods in Nepal," Jaishankar said.

"Was moved to hear their experience first hand. Thank the Nepali Army and Government for this rescue effort. Appreciate Embassy of India, Kathmandu's facilitation

of their smooth return to India," he added.

Speaking to reporters at Delhi airport, Jaishankar said the government's immediate focus remained on contacting all Indians who were in Nepal and had not yet been accounted for.

"We are still very much focused on contacting all the Indians who are there. We believe a little more than 300, the exact number keeps going up and down, about 315 Indians are still not being contacted," he said.

The comments came as Nepal continued to grapple with the aftermath of catastrophic flash floods in the Bhotekoshi River area of Rasuwa.

According to an update issued by Nepal's National Disaster Risk Reduction and Management Authority (NDRRMA), the death toll had risen to 538 as of 3 pm local time on Friday, while 977 people



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar and others during a meeting to discuss the relief and rescue efforts underway following a flash flood in Nepal PTI

remained missing.

The figures underline the devastating scale of the disaster as authorities continue search, rescue and relief operations in the affected areas following the catastrophic flooding on Wednesday.

Of the 538 bodies recovered so far, the highest number was recorded in Chitwan, where 221 bodies were recovered, followed by Nawalparasi East with 134.

Authorities recovered 46 bodies or human remains in Gorkha, 37 in

Nuwakot, 33 in Dhading, 28 in Tanahun, 27 in Nawalparasi West and 12 in Rasuwa, according to the NDRRMA data.

The 977 people reported missing include foreign nationals, Nepali citizens living abroad who were visiting Nepal, security personnel and Government officials.

Foreign nationals account for 517 of those reported missing. Another 161 people were reported missing through the Rasuwa District Emergency Operations Centre (DEOC).

The list also includes 127 Nepali citizens living abroad who were visiting Nepal, while 66 people were reported missing through the Makwanpur DEOC.

Indian authorities have been coordinating with their Nepalese counterparts and the Embassy of India in Kathmandu to locate and facilitate the return of Indian nationals affected by the floods.

PM Modi celebrates Raksha Bandhan with schoolgirls at Lok Kalyan Marg

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday greeted people on Raksha Bandhan and expressed hope that the auspicious festival brings happiness, prosperity and success to everyone's lives.

Continuing the annual tradition, schoolgirls visited the prime minister's official residence at 7, Lok Kalyan Marg, where they tied 'rakhis' on his wrist. The prime minister shared photos and a video on Instagram showing the children tying rakhis. In the video, he was seen warmly interacting with the young visitors, shaking hands and high-fiving with them.

"Happy Raksha Bandhan. May this auspicious festival bring happiness, prosperity, and success to all your lives," Modi wrote in a social media post in Hindi. He also wished that the bond of affection,



Prime Minister Narendra Modi with school children and others during Raksha Bandhan celebration at his residence in New Delhi PTI

togetherness and mutual trust remains eternal. "Some memorable moments from Raksha Bandhan celebrations at 7, Lok Kalyan Marg. May this festival deepen the bonds of affection and harmony. May it bring happiness and prosperity to everyone," he wrote in the post.

On his interaction with children, he wrote, "High-fives, smiles and more during today's Raksha Bandhan celebrations at 7, LKM".

One of the children asked

the prime minister what his childhood dream was. Modi replied, "Aap logo ko milna" (To meet you all).

Raksha Bandhan is a Hindu festival that celebrates the bond between brothers and sisters. On the occasion, sisters tie vibrant threads, or rakhis, on their brothers' wrists as a symbol of their heartfelt prayers and well wishes, and brothers reciprocate with thoughtful gifts and a promise to protect them under all circumstances.

Kuwait Ambassador receives cloud of hope volunteer team visiting India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Ambassador of the State of Kuwait to the Republic of India, HE Meshal Mustafa AlShemali, received Kuwait's "Cloud of Hope" volunteer team, which is visiting India as part of a humanitarian trip focused on healthcare, educational support and community empowerment.

The delegation comprises 30 volunteers from Kuwait, Bahrain and Saudi Arabia, including physicians, engineers, academics, educators and specialists.

Ambassador AlShemali commended the humanitarian, charitable and voluntary work undertaken by young men and women from Kuwait and other Gulf countries.

He said the initiatives reflect the authentic values deeply rooted in Gulf societies and described them as a shining example of social awareness and responsibility.

He also highlighted the important role played by



such initiatives in strengthening the presence and contribution of Gulf youth in international humanitarian action.

The Ambassador noted that charitable and humanitarian work is an intrinsic trait deeply ingrained in the people of Kuwait since ancient times.

He said their benevolent hands have reached the farthest corners of the world, responding to those in need and less fortunate, and extending assistance to all without discrimination.



He added that Kuwaiti society is guided by an enduring spirit of goodness and generosity, rooted in a firm belief in the values of mutual support, compassion and human solidarity.

During their visit to India, the delegation carried out a range of health, educational and relief initiatives, benefiting hundreds of children, families and members of the local community.

The activities included a voluntary medical day that benefited approximately 400 people through medical



check-ups, consultations and health awareness programmes. The team also distributed hundreds of school bags, school supplies, food items and basic necessities to vulnerable communities.

In addition, the volunteers organised educational and sports programmes and interactive activities for children and students.

The activities were aimed at fostering self-confidence, teamwork and positive competition. Sports equipment was also provided to enable the activities to con-

tinue after the team's visit concluded.

The trip builds on the "Cloud of Hope" team's long-standing record of international humanitarian work and reflects the ability of Gulf youth to set an exemplary model of cross-border volunteerism.

Spanning three countries, involving 30 volunteers and reaching hundreds of beneficiaries, the initiative brought participants together around a common message: "Hope is a universal human language understood by all."

3,400 SIR forms found at Navi Mumbai photocopy shop, five BLOs suspended

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thane/Mumbai

Five Booth Level Officers were suspended after 3,400 enumeration forms related to the Special Intensive Revision of voter rolls were found at a photocopy shop in Navi Mumbai, triggering a clash between Shiv Sena (UBT) and BJP activists, police and district officials said.

The Sena (UBT) workers confronted a man, who they claimed was an office-bearer of the BJP's Youth Wing, while he was allegedly getting SIR forms photocopied at a shop in the Kharghar area, police said on Friday. A BJP leader from Panvel said that the party workers had no connection with the matter.

A video related to the controversy was found on Thursday, following which the matter drew attention. The administration subsequently initiated an inquiry



into how the forms filled by voters reached a private photocopy centre.

Local police rushed to the scene and took the alleged BJP office-bearer into custody. Authorities also seized thousands of printed SIR forms from the premises and transferred them to the police station.

Sena (UBT) workers, meanwhile, alleged that the detained BJP youth leader managed to flee the Kharghar police station shortly after being brought in for questioning.

Raigad District Collector Kishan Jawale on Friday said a case has been registered against Suraj Patil under the Representation of the People Act and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. The authorities took action after the forms, pertaining to voters in the Panvel Assembly constituency, were found at the shop.

Jawale visited the office of Panvel Sub-Divisional Officer Pawan Chandak after taking serious note of the matter. The five BLOs were suspended pending disciplinary proceedings, he said.

Shah greets nation on World Sanskrit Day



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday extended greetings on the occasion of "World Sanskrit Day", terming the language the foundational basis of India's knowledge tradition, culture and consciousness. The home minister also greeted the citizens on Raksha Bandhan.

In a post on social media,, Shah said Sanskrit is the foundational basis of India's knowledge tradition, culture and consciousness, and the language is as scientific as it

is ancient. "The Vedas, Upanishads, and Shastras written in Sanskrit have been guiding humanity along the path of knowledge for centuries," he said. Shah paid his respects to all the scholars and teachers who have made unforgettable contributions to preserving the Sanskrit language and passing it on to new generations.

The government, in a statement, said, "Union Home Minister and Minister of Cooperation Shri Amit Shah extends Raksha Bandhan greetings to the people of the country on the occasion of Sawan Purnima."

High-powered task force invites suggestions on examination reforms

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A high-powered task force, set up by the Centre amid the recent protests by student bodies over paper leak allegations at the Jantar Mantar, on Friday invited public suggestions on comprehensive reforms in public examinations, including measures to fix accountability and strengthen institutional arrangements.

The Centre in July announced the constitution of the six-member high-powered task force (HPTF) chaired by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani to examine and recommend reforms related to the conduct, security, design and governance of public examinations — particularly those conducted by the National Testing Agency (NTA).

According to a statement issued by the Union Ministry of Personnel, the task force is



examining measures to strengthen institutional systems, ensure examination integrity, deploy appropriate technologies, augment infrastructure, promote accessibility, and safeguard student well-being.

The primary objective is to develop a robust, secure, transparent, equitable and future-ready public examination system, the ministry said in the statement.

Seeking to quell the unrest and incorporate ground-level feedback from the protesting students and academicians alike, the task force said it

considers it "extremely useful to benefit from the experience, knowledge and perspectives of all the stakeholders". Suggestions have been invited from students, parents, teachers, academic institutions, exam-conducting bodies and civil society organisations.

The key focus areas for public feedback include the conduct and security of examinations, assessment methodology, governance structures, accountability mechanisms, and the prevention, detection and redressal of malpractices.

Punjab Govt employees burn CM’s effigy over refusal to hold meeting

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hoshiarpur (Punjab)

Punjab government employees on Friday burnt an effigy of Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann and raised slogans against him in Hoshiarpur to protest his alleged “indifferent attitude” and refusal to meet with employee representatives, union leaders said.

The protest was organised outside the civil surgeon's office by the Joint Coordination Committee, formed by the Punjab Employees and Pensioners Joint Front and the Sanjha Mulazim Manch, Punjab.

The protesting employees also burnt copies of a government letter issued regarding the mass casual leave observed by employees on August 27, as well as copies of a post on X made by the chief minister on Thursday, in which he said that holding a meeting and continuing a protest could not take place simultaneously, the leaders said.

Addressing the protesters, the union leaders criticised what they described as Mann’s “arrogant attitude”



towards employees and demanded the immediate implementation of the Punjab and Haryana High Court’s decision regarding payment of dearness allowance (DA).

They also demanded that the government resolve the other demands listed in their memorandum, they said.

The leaders expressed gratitude for the large turnout of employees during the protest and the mass casual leave on

August 27. On Thursday, work was affected in various government departments and OPD services remained suspended in public hospitals in Punjab as over three lakh government employees went on a statewide strike pressing for their demands that included release of pending dearness allowance.

A scheduled meeting between Chief Minister Mann and representatives of the

employees’ bodies in Jalandhar was cancelled after he made it clear to the protesting employees that talks would be held only when they call off their strike.

The employees refused to call off their strike, insisting on holding an unconditional meeting.

Over 150 employees’ bodies under the banner of Punjab Sanjha Mulazam Manch have joined hands for the ‘maha hartal’.

CPI(M) calls NCLT debt settlement involving Subhash Chandra a ‘mockery of fair justice’

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ new Delhi

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) has criticised the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) for approving a repayment plan of ₹6.5 crore against claims amounting to ₹22,006.57 crore involving Zee Group founder and chairman Subhash Chandra. In a statement, the CPI(M) Polit Bureau described the decision as a “mockery of the principles of fair justice” and alleged that it reflected class bias on the part of the Tribunal.

According to the party, the lenders will suffer a loss of 99.97 percent under the approved settlement. It cited the case of LIC Housing Finance, which had a claim of ₹1,322.39 crore but has been approved a payment of only ₹38 lakh, or 0.028 per cent of its claim.

The CPI(M) also alleged that Chandra is known for his close ties to the BJP and the Sangh Parivar and said the NCLT order violated the judicial principle of the rule against bias.

The party expressed



concern over what it described as a consistent pattern in which large corporations are allowed to siphon off huge amounts of public money. It alleged that wilful defaulters are permitted to make large borrowings and, years later, have their debts settled through massive discounts under the insolvency process.

The CPI(M) said such settlements come at the expense of taxpayers and small depositors. It questioned why ordinary tax-

payers should bear the cost of defaults by large corporations and alleged that politically influential crony capitalists are provided large amounts of credit before being bailed out through what is described as a “haircut”.

The party contrasted the treatment of large corporate borrowers with that of poor and marginalised sections of society. It pointed out that thousands of indebted farmers, agricultural

workers, women and daily wage workers face severe distress, including suicides, over their inability to repay loans.

The CPI(M) also referred to household debt, which it said, citing RBI data, stands at an all-time high of 45.5 percent of GDP. It noted that loan waivers for farmers have often been questioned as an imprudent policy, while thousands of crores of corporate debt are being waived.

Individuals who do not want peace must be identified: Manipur CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

Manipur Chief Minister Y Khemchand Singh on Friday said individuals in the state who did not want peace needed to be identified.

Singh made the remarks at a guest lecture titled ‘On Manipur Situation: Prevailing Trust Deficit and the Path Towards Trust-Building’, organised by the Assam Rifles.

The CM said before the outbreak of violence in May 2023, he regularly travelled to the hill areas and witnessed an atmosphere of peace, harmony and cooperation among communities.

The violence, however, fundamentally changed the situation in the state, he said. On the prevailing trust deficit, Singh said it could not



be overcome merely through discussions or rhetoric but required sustained interaction, dialogue and understanding among communities.

Stating that restoration of peace is the foremost priority, Singh said the government would not compromise on this objective and that justice would be delivered to the victims.

He also said during his visits to various relief camps

and hill districts, he interacted with people from different communities and found that their common desire was to live in peace and return to their respective homes.

Singh also said certain individuals and groups who seek to spread conflict must be identified.

“There are people who do not want peace. We have to identify and correct them because common people want peace,” he said.

Singh also acknowledged the role of police, Assam Rifles and other security forces in protecting lives during the crisis and that members of different communities had also helped one another to save human lives during the difficult period.

Karnataka minister Nagendra resigns, slams manuwadis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Planning and Statistics Minister B Nagendra on Friday announced his resignation from the state Cabinet, 25 days after being re-induced, amid allegations linked to the Valmiki Corporation scam.

His announcement came shortly after he said he would meet Chief Minister DK Shivakumar and announce his decision at a press conference.

“Today I am voluntarily tendering my resignation as the minister,” an emotional Nagendra told reporters.

He said he had submitted his resignation to Shivakumar.

The Opposition BJP and JD(S) had been protesting his



re-induction into the Cabinet, two years after he resigned over the same issue.

They have alleged his involvement in the Rs 89-crore Karnataka Maharshi Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation scam.

Announcing his resignation in a choked voice, Nagendra compared the BJP’s targeting of him to

Lord Rama’s killing of Shambuka in the Ramayana and alleged that the “manuwadis”, apparently referring to the saffron party, never wanted a tribal person to rise.

Shambuka in the Uttara Kanda of the Valmiki Ramayana who, according to the text, was killed by Rama for performing penance.

Nagendra said he did not want to embarrass his party or allow the conspiracies of “manuwadis and vile communal forces” to gain an upper hand in state politics.

The BJP’s agitation in both Houses of the Karnataka Legislature had led to the abrupt adjournment sine die of the Monsoon session on August 24, three days ahead of its scheduled con-

Congress leaders slam Penguin India on Sonia memoir row



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Several Congress leaders lashed out at Penguin Random House India Friday, accusing it of refusing to publish Sonia Gandhi’s memoir in India with some claiming pressure was put on the publishing house to remove portions related to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the RSS, and “the occupation of Indian territory by China during Modi’s rule”.

The leaders also said the publisher’s “refusal” to publish the autobiography is a “murder of freedom of expression” and a matter of grave concern. Their reaction came after Penguin Random House India issued a statement saying it is not the publisher of Gandhi’s memoir “Belonging: A Journey of Love”. Earlier this month, American publisher Alfred A Knopf, an imprint of Penguin Random House, announced that the book would release on November 10. “Penguin Random House India is not the publisher of Belonging in India. Any suggestion that Penguin Random House India decided not to publish Belonging because the author declined editorial changes does not accurately reflect the circumstances,” Penguin India said. Its state-

ment followed a report in the Indian Express which claimed that the publisher backed out after Gandhi refused “editorial changes” to the manuscript.

Reacting to the development, senior Congress leader and former Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot said, “Penguin Worldwide is ready to publish Smt. Sonia Gandhi ji’s upcoming book worldwide in its original form, but Penguin Random House India wants changes made to launch it in India. After all, what is the reason or what pressure is there that what is being published across the world cannot be published in India?”

Sonia Gandhi’s life is an example of sacrifice and dedication, and the integrity and dignity with which she has served the country is exemplary, he said.

“Suppressing the book of Smt. Sonia Gandhi ji, a person of such stature, a senior leader of the nation, and former Leader of the Opposition, under pressure is tantamount to the murder of freedom of expression,” Gehlot said.

The real issue is that pressure was put on Penguin India to remove the portions related to Modi, the RSS, and the occupation of Indian territory by China during Modi’s rule.

Child’s stomach pain may not be just infection, could be appendicitis: Doctors advise caution

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Appendicitis in children can be difficult to recognise in its early stages as its symptoms may resemble those of common stomach infections, but delays in diagnosis can significantly increase the risk of appendix perforation and other complications, doctors said.

They said abdominal pain accompanied by vomiting, fever, loss of appetite or increasing tenderness should not be dismissed as a routine stomach infection, particularly when the pain persists or becomes progressively severe.

“Appendicitis in children usually presents with typical symptoms and signs which are apparent to a discerning doctor,” Dr Sandeep

Agarwala, Head of Department of Paediatric Surgery at AIIMS, Delhi, said.

“However, it does not always present in the textbook manner. A child usually has a vague central abdominal pain which, in a few hours, localises to the right lower abdomen. When this is associated with or preceded by loss of appetite, nausea and vomiting or fever, one should have a high index of suspicion of appendicitis,” Dr Agarwala said.

Appendicitis can frequently be mistaken for gastroenteritis, which typically has diarrhoea as a main symptom, Agarwala said.

“The important point is to watch how the symptoms evolve and seek medical evaluation when the pain persists or worsens,” he said.

Younger children pose a



particular diagnostic challenge as they may not be able to clearly describe or localise their pain, he said.

“In them, the diagnosis can be delayed, and therefore complications like perforation may be higher,” Agarwala said.

According to Dr Shandip

Kumar Sinha, Director of Paediatric Surgery and Paediatric Urology at Medanta — The Medicity in Gurugram, parents may initially assume that the child has a stomach infection and wait for the symptoms to settle, but appendicitis can progress, and in young chil-

dren the progression may be faster.

“Persistent abdominal pain, particularly when associated with fever, vomiting or refusal to eat, warrants medical assessment,” he said, adding that the consequences of delayed diagnosis have also been highlighted in larger studies.

He said appendicitis may begin with pain around the navel before shifting towards the lower right side, although this pattern is not seen in every child. Nausea, vomiting, fever and loss of appetite are also common symptoms.

“Diagnosis should be based on the child’s symptoms and physical examination, supported by investigations when required. Ultrasound can be particularly useful in children because it does not involve

radiation, but an inconclusive scan should not provide false reassurance if clinical suspicion remains high,” Dr Sinha said.

Imaging decisions need to be individualised, with ultrasound commonly used in children and further imaging considered when the clinical picture and initial findings do not match, he said.

Agarwala said that once appendicitis is confirmed, surgical removal of the appendix remains a standard treatment in cases of acute appendicitis even when associated with perforation and peritonitis.

The presence of a localised abscess in the right lower abdomen may mandate initial drainage of the abscess followed by delayed or interval appendicitis.

Mumbai auto, taxi fare hike sparks concern among commuters; unions frown over meagre rate boost

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The fare hike for autorickshaws and black-and-yellow cabs in the Mumbai Metropolitan Region has sparked concerns among commuters who fear the addition will burden their household budgets, even as union leaders demanded that the government reconsider the Rs 1 revision.

The concerns of commuters stem from the Mumbai Metropolitan Region Transport Authority (MMRTA) approving a ₹1 increase in the minimum fare for autorickshaws and a ₹2 hike for taxis, effective September 1.

The minimum autorickshaw fare will rise to ₹27 from ₹26, while the minimum taxi fare for the first 1.5 km will increase to



₹33 from ₹31.

“Bus fares have increased, taxi fares are going up, and petrol and diesel prices are rising, while salaries remain stagnant. This is wrong, isn’t it? If you increase, then increase everything; do it for everyone, for poor people also. If you are hiking petrol and diesel prices, raise the salary of poor people also,” a commuter working in Colaba told PTI Videos.

Another commuter,

Sarfaraz Ahmed, a resident of Kalyan in Thane district, said rising prices are already affecting daily expenses.

“Inflation affects us every day. We were travelling by autos where the fare was ₹20, but now it has become ₹25 or ₹30. There is no control over prices,” Ahmed said.

Swapan, a resident of Wadala in Mumbai, said the fare hike would impact everyone as the cost of essential commodities had

already risen sharply.

“Inflation has reached the sky and life has become very difficult. Now taxi fares are also increasing, which will make things even more difficult,” he said.

Balasaheb Mhaske, another passenger, also opposed the increase, saying that even a ₹2 rise could cause hardship to poorer sections.

“How will poor people manage with the increase? Everything keeps becoming more expensive. Sugar has reached around ₹100 a kg. What will people eat?” he questioned.

A city-based autorickshaw union, meanwhile, has urged the Maharashtra government to reconsider the Rs 1 hike, saying it was inadequate to offset the rise in fuel, maintenance, insurance and other operating costs.

Industry reviving in Nashik after decade-long decline: CM Fadnavis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Nashik

Nashik’s industrial growth had slowed down for some time but the city is now witnessing a revival and will emerge as an important growth engine of Maharashtra in the next five years, Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said on Saturday.

Speaking after inaugurating the administrative building of Pune’s Savitribai Phule University’s Nashik sub-centre, Fadnavis said the industrial growth of the north Maharashtra city faltered in the first decade of the current millennium as several difficulties emerged.

Investment increased in industrial areas around Chhatrapati Sambhajnagar and Pune, but that in Nashik stagnated, he said.

“But I am very happy that over the last 10-12 years, Nashik has been projected in different ways and different



Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis inaugurates the new building of Late Dulaji Nana Patil Agriculture College of Maratha Vidya Prasarak Samaj (MVPS) at Chachadgaon in Nashik district on Friday. State ministers Chihagan Bhujbal, Narahari Zirwal, Girish Mahajan and Dada Bhuse, Congress MP Shobha Bachhav, MVPS general secretary Nitin Thakare and others were present on the occasion. MVPS also hands over a cheque of ₹25 lakh to the CM’s Relief Fund

PTI

capabilities have been created here. Today, once again, Nashik is getting reborn...,” said Fadnavis who also heads the finance department. “In the next five years, Nashik will be one of the most important growth engines of Maharashtra,” he added. The upcoming

Vadhavan Port in neighbouring Palghar would open up new opportunities for Nashik, he said. “We are developing a route to directly connect Nashik with Vadhavan Port. Because of this route, Nashik will become the most important centre for engineering, logistics and exports,”

Fadnavis added. Educational institutes must design their courses by keeping in mind the sectors that would generate jobs in the future, he said. “We have to think about which sectors will create the maximum number of jobs. Accordingly, we will have to prepare our syllabus, courses and degrees. We will have to create ‘sandwich’ courses, which bring different courses together,” the chief minister said. One can not think of any field of knowledge “in a silo”, he further said. “No person can work by thinking only of one stream (of knowledge). In medicine, there is biotechnology which combines medicine and engineering. In engineering, along with physics and chemistry, we also have to consider biological sciences in a different way,” Fadnavis said. Universities should become centres of incubation and innovation, he said.



Editor's

TAKE

SCO@25: An unending search for relevance

The real test for the SCO is whether it can be effective in addressing the security and economic challenges confronting the region

Prime Minister Narendra Modi begins a four-day Central Asian trip on August 29 with a state visit to Uzbekistan, ahead of the twenty-sixth Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit in Bishkek on August 31-September 1. The timing is apt: the SCO turns twenty-five this year, and the region is more volatile than ever before. In Tashkent, on his fourth visit to Uzbekistan, the agenda is familiar: trade, investment, defence, digital connectivity, energy and education. What is new is the framing - aligning India's Viksit Bharat 2047 with Uzbekistan's own 2030 vision, alongside symbolic stops at the Lal Bahadur Shastri memorial and the Gandhi Centre at Tashkent State University.

At Bishkek, host Kyrgyzstan has set the theme, "25 Years of the SCO: Together Towards Sustainable Peace, Development and Prosperity." The agenda is ambitious on paper: an international centre against organised crime, cybercrime cooperation, a proposed SCO development bank, climate and disaster-response mechanisms, and connectivity flagships like the \$4.7-billion China-Kyrgyzstan-Uzbekistan railway. India will press its own additions to widen the grouping beyond hydrocarbons and hard security.

Judged by scale, the record is not trivial. From six founding states in 2001, the SCO has grown to ten, plus a wide circle of dialogue partners, together accounting for roughly a third of global output. It has kept China and Russia in structured dialogue and given counter-terrorism cooperation an institutional home via its Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure. But scale has not brought capability. Institutional thinness and scant common financial resources are long-flagged weaknesses; the SCO has never furnished troops or material support in a crisis, and its consensus-based design - a virtue when sold as non-confrontational - doubles as a recipe for paralysis whenever members disagree.

And disagree they do. The India-Pakistan impasse has hollowed out the counter-terrorism cooperation the SCO was built around, stalling joint exercises and intelligence-sharing, while China's quiet tilt towards Islamabad has repeatedly let Pakistan blunt India's language on cross-border terrorism. India's Central Asia trade, at roughly two billion dollars, is a rounding error beside China's near-hundred-billion-dollar footprint there, and connectivity India actually needs - the International North-South Transport Corridor chief among them - remains stalled for reasons no communiqué will address.

Layered atop this, India's multi-aligned foreign policy sits uneasily inside a grouping centred on a Russia-China axis. None of this argues for disengagement; walking away would simply cede Central Asia to Beijing and Moscow by default. It argues for calibrated expectations instead. India's security concerns are better pursued bilaterally than through a forum where Pakistan is present. Routes that bypass Pakistan altogether, via Chabahar and Iran, deserve more sustained attention than another round of summit rhetoric. On present evidence, the Tashkent leg will likely outlast the Bishkek one in consequence - itself, twenty-five years on, the most honest verdict on the SCO.

Rebuilding India's Gorkha bridge with Nepal

The Gorkha soldier once served as one of the strongest human bridges between India and Nepal. Today, that bridge is narrower. Delhi's challenge is to forge a new generation of substantive ties with Nepal — strong enough to withstand and absorb the shocks of future political upheavals, border disputes or diplomatic disagreements.



BHOPINDER SINGH

India-Nepal relations have never been merely a matter of treaties, trade figures or diplomatic communiqués. Geography made the two countries neighbours; history, culture and religion made them close, but for generations, one institution gave that relationship its most powerful human expression, ie, the Gorkha soldier in the Indian Army.

From Nepal's monarchy through successive phases of Nepali Congress governments, Left parties of varying hues, the Gorkha soldier remained an extraordinary living link between Kathmandu and New Delhi. Young men from Nepal's hills enlisted in the Indian Army, served with distinction, retired to their villages and carried home not merely pensions and memories, but a personal familiarity with India. This was soft power in its most organic form. It was also a relationship built on sacrifice, loyalty and shared military traditions. The Gorkha Regiments became one of the most visible manifestations of the India-Nepal relationship, while Indian Army recruitment gave the bilateral relationship a constituency that no embassy or foreign ministry could manufacture. That bridge, however, has been badly weakened.

The introduction of the Agniveer recruitment system has fundamentally altered the attractiveness of military service. Its implications for Nepal's Gorkha recruitment cannot be brushed aside. This also coincided with a reduction in recruitment from Nepal. The consequence is more serious than a decline in numbers. A decades-old social ecosystem is being disrupted. The danger for New Delhi is that it may underestimate what this means politically. The Gorkha connection was never simply about manpower for the Indian Army. It was an instrument of familiarity and trust between societies. It gave India an enduring human presence in Nepal, and Nepal an enduring stake in India's military institutions. If that channel becomes marginal, India loses something that cannot easily be recreated through conventional diplomacy.

The recent exchange of honorary Generalships between the chiefs of the Indian and Nepali armies was therefore welcome and heartening. Such gestures matter. Military institutions possess a special vocabulary of camaraderie, and public recognition by one army of the other can reassure both establishments that the foundational relationship remains intact. But symbolism has limits. This question has become more urgent as



THE GORKHA RELATIONSHIP SHOULD BE REVISITED IMAGINATIVELY. IF THE AGNIVEER FRAMEWORK IS TO REMAIN INDIA'S MODEL FOR RECRUITMENT, NEW DELHI AND KATHMANDU MUST EXPLORE MECHANISMS THAT PRESERVE THE ATTRACTIVENESS OF SERVICE FOR NEPALI CITIZENS WHILE RESPECTING INDIA'S NEW MILITARY REQUIREMENTS

The writer is a former Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Puducherry, and a military veteran

choices are increasingly shaped by a younger, more assertive and digitally connected generation. Shared history and cultural affinity remain important, but they cannot be the sole foundation of a modern bilateral relationship. Connectivity, economic opportunity, technology, education and mobility increasingly determine how young Nepalis perceive India.

This is why India should view the Gorkha relationship not simply as a relic of the past, but as a template for the future. The lesson of the Gorkha soldier is that durable influence is created when ordinary people have a personal stake in the relationship. India needs to recreate that principle across multiple sectors.

The relationship with Nepal has survived monarchies, republics, ideological transformations and political upheavals. It will survive the present phase too. But survival should not be confused with strength.

The Gorkha soldier once served as one of the strongest human bridges between India and Nepal. That bridge is now narrower. Honorary Generalships can remind us of its importance; humanitarian assistance can demonstrate goodwill; but neither can rebuild it on its own. Delhi's challenge is therefore larger than repairing an old military arrangement. It is to create a new generation of substantive bonds with Nepal, strong enough that when the next political upheaval, border dispute or diplomatic disagreement arrives, the relationship has sufficient depth to absorb the shock.

That will require less symbolism, more substance, and above all, recognition that the most enduring foreign policy is ultimately built not between governments, but between people, like the gallant, loyal and trustworthy Gorkha soldier.

When strangers become our own



SANJAY CHANDRA

2ND OPINION

I recently moderated a conversation with a friend about his book *On Angels' Wings*. He was only seventeen when he lost his entire family in the bombing of Air India Flight 182, Kanishka. The book is a moving account of the tragedy and the long quest of the families for justice.

The aircraft went down off the coast of Ireland. As we spoke about the events that followed, one aspect stayed with me-the compassion shown by the local people towards the families who had travelled there after losing their loved ones. They were complete strangers, arriving in another country in circumstances nobody should ever have to face. Yet people opened not merely their doors but also their hearts to them. Their grief somehow became a shared grief.

A few weeks later, I was watching a series about

another aviation tragedy-the bombing of Pan Am Flight 103 over Lockerbie in Scotland in 1988. Debris was scattered over a vast area, with Lockerbie itself suffering deaths on the ground. And once again, what struck me was the response of ordinary people. The residents of Lockerbie reached out to families they had never met. They offered comfort and companionship of a kind that official systems, however well-intentioned, could seldom provide.

These accounts reminded me of experiences from my own years in the Railways. Railway accidents sometimes occurred in remote locations accessible only through narrow village roads. By the time railway teams could reach the site, the nearby villagers were invariably already there. Many had very little to spare themselves. Yet that seldom seemed to matter. They helped the injured, brought whatever food and water they could arrange, and stayed around to assist those involved in rescue and restoration. I remember being deeply moved by such gestures. Nobody had instructed them to help. Someone was in distress, and helping seemed the most natural thing to do.

Years later, I find myself wondering about the apparent contradiction in human behaviour.

The same human beings who can display extraordinary compassion towards complete strangers can also become divided over matters that, viewed from a distance, sometimes appear insignificant. Communities that come together during an accident, flood or other

tragedy can, at another time, find themselves confronting one another over differences of identity, belief or ideology. Why? Perhaps suffering does something that ordinary life does not. When we encounter someone who has lost a child, a parent or an entire family, the labels with which we normally identify people temporarily disappear. We do not first see nationality, religion, language, social standing or political belief. We see another human being in pain. A stranger ceases, for that moment, to be a stranger.

Our everyday lives are different. We have the time and space to notice what distinguishes us from others. Differences get emphasised, grievances acquire histories and opinions gradually become positions we feel compelled to defend.

Yet the responses I have witnessed in times of tragedy make me believe that compassion lies closer to our natural instincts than many of those divisions. Perhaps tragedy does not suddenly make people kinder. It merely strips away, for a while, the layers that prevent that kindness from expressing itself.

The question that remains with me is a simple one. If we can so easily recognise our shared humanity when confronted with another person's suffering, why must we wait for tragedy to remind us that strangers can also be our own?

The writer is a founder of Kala - Krazy About Literature And Arts, is an author, speaker, coach, arbitrator, and strategy consultant

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

India's pragmatic SCO strategy

This refers to the article "SCO Summit: India's Eurasian balancing act" (August 28, 2026). India's participation in the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation should be viewed through the lens of national interest rather than ideological alignment. In a region marked by competing powers and shifting partnerships, the SCO offers India an opportunity to engage with Central Asia, address security concerns and strengthen connectivity. At the same time, New Delhi must remain cautious about initiatives linked to the China-Pakistan axis that may undermine its strategic interests. India should use the forum actively without allowing its independent foreign policy to be constrained by other members' priorities. Engagement with Russia and the Central Asian republics remains important, particularly on energy, trade, counter-terrorism and regional stability.

The SCO can address terrorism, but declarations must lead to intelligence-sharing and concrete action.

India's challenge is to maintain constructive engagement while retaining strategic autonomy. The Bishkek summit offers an opportunity to deepen India's Eurasian engagement. A balanced, pragmatic approach, supported by stronger bilateral ties, would serve India's interests well.

M BARATHI | BENGALURU

Making Lokpal more effective

With reference to "Lokpal Must Act, Not Just Wait" (August 28, 2026), The article rightly highlights an important weakness in India's anti-corruption framework: institutions created to ensure accountability cannot remain effective if they depend excessively on complaints and procedural limitations. The Lokpal was intended to provide an independent mechanism for addressing serious allegations, but its powers must operate within a clear legal framework that protects both public interest and individual rights.

The Lokpal, Central Vigilance Commission and other investigating agencies should have better coordination while avoiding duplication. Clear rules should specify when the Lokpal can initiate a preliminary inquiry based on credible information and how cases should be referred for investigation. Time-bound procedures and transparent reporting would also improve public confidence.

Safeguards against frivolous complaints are essential. The system must act promptly, fairly and with adequate staffing, investigators and access to information. The Lokpal must become a credible, independent and efficient part of India's accountability system, acting firmly when evidence warrants intervention while remaining answerable to the law.

A SENTHIL KUMAR | TAMIL NADU

Prepare better for Himalayan disasters

Apropos "Himalayan catastrophe" (August 28), The tragedy described in the article is a stark reminder that disasters in the Himalayas cannot be treated as isolated national emergencies. Glacial retreat, unstable slopes and increasingly erratic weather are creating risks across a region where rivers, mountains and hazards ignore political boundaries. Development in fragile areas without regard for environmental realities is worrying.

The priority should be real-time monitoring of glaciers, glacial lakes and vulnerable valleys. Nepal, India and China must share weather and hydrological data to enable timely warnings and save lives. Equally important is how infrastructure is planned. Roads, hydropower projects, bridges and settlements in sensitive zones must undergo rigorous scientific assessment. Early-warning systems should reach residents, pilgrims and travellers, not remain confined to government agencies and research institutions. India should strengthen cooperation with its Himalayan neighbours through joint scientific studies, compatible warning systems and regular disaster-response exercises. Climate change is global, but preparedness is within governments' control. The Himalayas need better monitoring, safer construction and stronger cooperation, with equal focus on prevention and relief.

A MYILSAMI | COIMBATORE

PIC TALK



People celebrate 'Raksha Bandhan' festival at Jama Masjid, in New Delhi. PHOTO: PTI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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NEPAL FLOODS DEMAND URGENT RESCUE, RELIEF AND PREPAREDNESS

The devastating flash floods in Nepal, with the reported death toll rising to 392, have triggered a humanitarian crisis of alarming proportions. The reported 255 Indians still missing, alongside 84 who have been rescued, has caused deep anguish among families anxiously awaiting news of their loved ones. The scale of the tragedy calls for an immediate and coordinated response, with every possible effort directed towards rescue, recovery and relief.

Authorities in India and Nepal should intensify operations in the worst-affected areas and deploy helicopters, rescue teams, medical personnel and modern communication systems. Identifying missing persons and establishing their whereabouts must be the highest priority. Families should receive regular, verified updates through dedicated helplines and official information

centres. Displaced communities also need food, clean water, medicines, shelter and psychological support.

The disaster highlights the Himalayan region's vulnerability to extreme weather. India and Nepal must strengthen early-warning systems, weather monitoring and disaster-response networks, while sharing real-time weather and satellite data to reduce future casualties. The present crisis must become a lesson for the future. Himalayan development cannot be separated from environmental sustainability and disaster resilience. Both countries need safer infrastructure, improved evacuation routes and better-trained local response teams. India should continue assisting Nepal and work tirelessly to trace missing Indian citizens. This tragedy demands compassion today and action tomorrow.

YASHASWI BAIRAGI | UJJAIN

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India-China and the test of trust

India and China are attempting to manage a difficult relationship through dialogue, confidence-building and limited border agreements. But the real test lies in whether these measures can build trust and eventually contribute to a broader settlement, rather than simply making a deeply unresolved dispute more manageable



Delhi's intellectual discussion on China is indefensible in its intensity, while much of the wider social discussion rarely rises above the level of lay discourse. Some say engagement is the answer, others instinctively distrust Beijing, while a smaller group argues that India has little choice but to go along with China. Last week in New Delhi, I attended a discussion on China's grand strategy in which senior retired diplomats, military leaders and strategic thinkers argued over precisely this problem. The room was full of people from different generations who listened carefully, took notes and asked difficult questions. What was striking was not agreement but the absence of any easy answer. Meanwhile, National Security Adviser Ajit Doval travelled to Beijing for the 25th round of Special Representatives' talks with Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi, while India's External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar was in Moscow. The juxtaposition was revealing. India is attempting to manage several strategic theatres simultaneously, at a moment when the international system is becoming considerably less predictable. The India-China question can no longer be treated as a narrow Himalayan dispute. It is becoming one of the central tests of whether Asia can construct its own security order or remain trapped in rivalries shaped by powers operating beyond the continent.

The immediate question is what exactly happened in Beijing on August 25. The answer is more complicated than the increasingly casual description of an India-China "early harvest" suggests. The two sides agreed on eight points, including advancing discussions on an "Early and Substantial Harvest" concerning boundary delimitation and border management, establishing additional military meeting points and hotlines, improving mechanisms for dealing with incidents along the Line of Actual Control, expanding border cooperation, resuming discussions on trans-border rivers and holding the 26th Special Representatives' meeting in India in 2027. Both governments also reaffirmed the 2005 Agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for the Settlement of the India-China Boundary Question as the framework for pursuing a fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable settlement.

The Indian and Chinese statements are substantially aligned on the eight outcomes, but the political interpretation surrounding them is not necessarily identical. The crucial phrase is "Early and Substantial Harvest". That formulation leaves open an important question about sequencing. Can progress in selected areas of boundary delimitation and border management generate sufficient confidence for a wider settlement, or could a series of limited arrangements gradually become a substitute for resolving the larger territorial dispute? That is not a semantic question. It goes to the heart of whether the present process is designed to move towards a settlement or simply to make an unresolved dispute more manageable.

This is why the 2005 agreement cannot be treated as diplomatic wallpaper. It established political parameters and guiding principles for settlement and remains the principal framework repeatedly invoked by both sides. The significance of the present moment is therefore not that India and China have suddenly discovered dialogue. They have been talking for decades. The significance is that the two governments are now experimenting with how much of the boundary problem can be separated into manageable components while retaining the broader political framework intended to guide a settlement. That distinction will determine whether the present process becomes a bridge towards settlement or another mechanism for postponing it.

There is a bumpy historical lesson here. India has repeatedly approached China through the assumption that political reassurance, personal diplomacy and incremental accommodation can create sufficient confidence for the substantive territorial question eventually to become negotiable. Beijing has generally approached the problem differently. It has tended to combine negotiations with military preparation, economic leverage, diplomatic positioning and the gradual creation of facts on the ground. This does not mean every Chinese move is part of a single secret master plan. That interpretation is too simplistic. China's strategy is more sophisticated precisely because different instruments can reinforce one another without nec-



THE REAL CHALLENGE IS TO ESTABLISH WHETHER BEIJING AND NEW DELHI CAN NEGOTIATE WITHOUT TRYING TO DECEIVE ONE ANOTHER ABOUT THE NATURE OF THE BARGAIN. INDIA NEEDS TO KNOW WHETHER AN EARLY HARVEST IS GENUINELY INTENDED AS A PATHWAY TOWARDS A WIDER SETTLEMENT OR WHETHER IT COULD EVENTUALLY FREEZE THE STATUS QUO IN WAYS THAT FAVOUR THE STRONGER SIDE

The writer is a columnist based in Colombo

essarily being directed through one visible blueprint.

That point was made forcefully during the New Delhi discussion I attended. The argument was not that China possesses a single document called a "grand strategy" which explains everything Beijing does. Rather, there is a remarkable continuity in China's strategic direction across different leaderships. One speaker traced this through the Chinese idea of national rejuvenation, arguing that it did not begin with Xi Jinping and cannot simply be explained by communism. China's territorial conception, the importance attached to Tibet and the broader desire to restore national strength have deeper roots. The distinction matters because it prevents India from making the convenient mistake of believing that the problem will disappear with a change of Chinese leadership.

The ancient strategic tradition also deserves more serious attention than the fashionable invocation of Sun Tzu. "Winning without fighting" is frequently quoted as though it were a Chinese instruction manual for modern geopolitics. According to Professor Srikanth Kondapalli of Jawaharlal Nehru University, it is not. But the wider intellectual tradition does contain a persistent emphasis on shaping circumstances before confrontation becomes necessary. Zhang Yi, the strategist of the Warring States period, offered a particularly revealing conception of power. His description of Qin was not simply about battlefield strength. Territory, economic resources, military organisation, geography, disciplined administration and the ability to deter opponents were treated as mutually reinforcing components of national power. The lesson for modern India is not to imitate ancient China. It is to understand that negotiations take place within a structure of relative power. Diplomacy does not suspend asymmetry. It operates inside it.

This is why the early-harvest idea is both attractive and dangerous. Better border communication, military hotlines and procedures can help prevent local incidents from escalating. The agreement's emphasis on prompt diplomatic and military communication is therefore important.

One of the strongest points raised during the New Delhi discussion was that India's most credible advantage against a vastly larger Chinese economy and military establishment may not come from trying to match China platform for platform on land. India's geography gives it leverage across the Indian Ocean. It does not mean India should seek confrontation with the Chinese Navy. It means India possesses strategic geography that can complicate China's calculations. Conventional deterrence therefore need not mean threatening war. It can mean making the costs of coercion sufficiently uncertain that coercion becomes unattractive.

China understands this logic. That is precisely why its maritime presence in the Indian Ocean has expanded and why its relationships with Pakistan and other countries surrounding India matter. Beijing does not need to defeat India directly to constrain Indian strategic freedom. It can impose costs across multiple fronts, keep Indian military resources tied down in the Himalayas, deepen its economic penetration of South Asia and strengthen relationships in India's immediate neighbourhood. The strategic problem for New Delhi is therefore not one Chinese tank or one disputed mountain. It is the cumulative effect of several pressures operating simultaneously.

The real challenge is to establish whether Beijing and New Delhi can negotiate without trying to deceive one another about the nature of the bargain. India needs to know whether an early harvest is genuinely intended as a pathway towards a wider settlement or whether it could eventually freeze the status quo in ways that favour the stronger side. China needs to know whether India's strategic partnerships are intended to contain China or simply to preserve India's freedom of action. Both sides have legitimate security concerns. Neither has the luxury of pretending that the other will disappear.

Nepal tragedy: Why hide the real cause?



ACHARYA PRASHANT

it had made and came down all at once into Nepal's Rasuwa district, carrying everything away: whole villages, the bridges, the roads, more than ten hydroelectric projects along the bank, everything. Hundreds are confirmed dead, and more than a thousand are missing; hundreds of the missing are foreign nationals, among them Indian, American, British and Australian pilgrims who had set out on the sacred road to Kailash. The mountain checked no one's passport. And it was not a monsoon flood, rain the ground could not absorb. It was the second kind of flood, the kind that no longer needs rain.

And here is the part that the word "flood" hides. No rain had fallen that day. No cloud had burst. This disaster did not come down from the sky as water; it came down from the mountain as ice. And why did the glacier break? Because the Himalayas are heating, and heat applied to a great body of ice breaks it. What is already settled is that warming loaded the gun and has been loading it for decades, and that is the cause, whatever the trigger.

The one word that should not merely be spoken but shouted, climate, is the one being stepped around. That avoidance is not an oversight. It is the first disaster and the deepest, the refusal to see what has already been seen, and written on every warning list, for years.

This same small river had flooded in almost exactly this way fourteen months earlier, in the summer of 2025, when a glacial lake up in Tibet, swollen by a spell of high

mountain heat, overflowed and drained without warning. One small river. Fourteen months. Two catastrophes. This is not coincidence; it is a pattern. Five years ago, ICIMOD, the region's mountain-research institute, drew up an inventory of the glacial lakes most likely to burst into Nepal's rivers, and found forty-seven of them dangerous. This flood did not fall on a place nobody was watching. It fell on a place that had been marked on paper, in an official inventory, for years.

And no one in India should imagine this is a neighbour's tragedy. The stream that flooded is a headwater of the Trishuli, and the Trishuli feeds the Narayani, which crosses into India as the Gandak, runs down through Bihar, and pours into the Ganga a little above Patna. The water that came down as ruin in Rasuwa this week is, a little downstream and a little later, the irrigation of our fields and the aarti at our ghats. The pilgrims who died were walking India's sacred geography, and that geography is the melting one: Kailash and Gangotri, Kedarnath and Badrinath all stand on the same thawing ice. It is an arm of the Ganga. The wound cut into the Himalayas bleeds out across the plains below, the Indian plains.

Now let's put the question that no one is putting. Who heated the glacier? Not the monsoon, which stayed away; not the mountain, which only held the ice. We did. Outside, there are instruments; inside, there are none. We can measure a river to the centimetre and the air to a tenth of a degree, and about the desire that set the whole machine in motion we can say almost nothing, because no dial has been built for it and no satellite can be turned to face inward.

The climate crisis is not, at bottom, a technical problem. It is a disorder in the ordinary human interior. The emptiness within is bottomless, and so the consumption must be bottomless too, and to consume without end some eight billion of us must burn the earth without end. Consumption is emission; between the two there is no gap at all. Everything that you love is carbon dioxide. Nobody loves CFCs, but you love the tea, and that is the problem. So the ice of the Himalayas is not melting in any factory's furnace. It is melting in our tendencies, in the ego itself. The mountain is not taking revenge; it is only where the ice happened to be. That flood did not come from the cloud, and it did not finally come from the glacier. It came from the way we have been taught to see life.

Nepal is responsible for about a tenth of one per cent of the world's greenhouse gases; the people this flood killed had burned almost nothing at all, and those who burned the most were nowhere near the water. And yet the deepest flaw in the complaint, justified as every word of it is, is the belief that there are other people at all.

So the answer, too, is not outside but within, because that is where the crisis began. Green technologies are necessary and policies are necessary, but they are not sufficient, and alone they will fail. The only measure equal to the cause is a mass education of the self. Self-knowledge is the least environmentalism. Ask what a sane relationship with the earth would look like, and the honest reply is that it cannot be drawn up in advance. There can be no definition. All that can be done is to hold up a light, and then leave the rest to the person. Seeing, by itself, changes nothing; it is only the point at which change first becomes possible. The way out is the way in.

That flood was not a piece of news. It was a mirror. Nature is holding it up to us again and again, and breaking the mirror will not change the face in it. The only question left is whether we still have the courage, and the honesty, to look, and to see that the face is our own.

Acharya Prashant is a philosopher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life



India's talent hunt must look beyond the Olympics



DEEPTI GUPTA

seems a good day for a parent to say something out loud.

A fortnight ago, from the Red Fort, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said the thing few leaders say about their own country. There are roughly 40 sports and some 350 events at the Olympic Games, and India does not play or qualify in nearly two-thirds of them. So a talent hunt will now go into every village, every city and every school to find children between five and fifteen, train them properly, and prepare them for the Games of 2036.

It takes honesty to admit that, and he is right about the fix. For too long we have gone to the Olympics to see how a handful of our best fare rather than to compete across the field. Finding children early and staying with them for a decade is the only method that has ever worked anywhere.

I want to place one thought alongside that ambition, as a parent rather than as an expert. Some of India's most capable young athletes

compete in sports that are not on the Olympic list at all. Motorsport is one of them. There is no karting event at the Games, no Formula car, no chequered flag in the closing ceremony. So when the nets are cast for 2036, a certain kind of child will simply not be caught in them, no matter how good she is or who she has already beaten.

I know this because I am raising one.

My daughter Arshi is nine. In only her second year of competitive racing she won the Indian National Karting Championship 2025 in the Micro Max category, the youngest ever to do so in this country, among boys and girls both. She is today the only female national-level karting champion in Asia, and the youngest driver in the world selected for the F1 Academy Discover Your Drive Programme. In June she received the FIA President's Medal from the FMSCI, and she has stood on an international podium in the UK and UAE.

I set these down only because they are the sort of facts that would ordinarily place a child inside a national programme.



One thing about karting deserves to be said plainly. It is a mixed-gender sport. Girls and boys race the same karts, on the same circuit, at the same speeds, and the timing screen does not know the difference. Whatever my daughter has won, she has won against boys. In a country still working out how to get girls onto

mission is only that the search be defined more generously than the Olympic programme defines it.

India has never had a driver stand on a Formula 1 podium. Two Indians have raced in the sport, a few have reached Formula 2, and we built a world-class circuit outside Delhi and

playing fields at all, that is not a small thing.

What it costs is the part nobody sees. A racing kart is not a bat or a pair of spikes. There are engines, tyres, spares, entry fees, a mechanic, a coach, testing days, and flights to England or Dubai, because the racing that develops a driver is not all available here. We have carried most of this ourselves and been fortunate to be able to. I think often about the children who have her aptitude and none of that cushion. Their talent will not announce itself. Somebody has to go and look.

That is precisely what the Prime Minister has promised to do. My sub-

then let the race go. Motorsport remains one of the most watched sporting properties on earth, followed in exactly the markets where this government wants Indian excellence to register. A tricolour on an F1 podium would do for India's standing abroad what a great many campaigns cannot.

None of this needs a new ministry. It needs non-Olympic disciplines written into the talent hunt's terms of reference rather than left out, and a funding window a child already on a recognised international pathway can actually apply to. It also needs Indian industry, which the Prime Minister rightly asked to think globally, to see that backing a young driver is not charity but one of the cheapest routes an Indian brand has to a global audience.

My daughter will keep racing either way. We will keep finding the money and she will keep getting into the kart, because at nine she has already decided what she wants. But whether India has a racing champion within the decade, and whether that champion is a girl, is not really up to her.

Dhyan Chand was not made by a scheme. He was made by a country in which his game was everywhere he looked, so that a boy with an unreasonable gift could not go unnoticed. That is the real work of a talent hunt, and it is why the net has to be cast wider than a list of events. The rest of it is up to us.

Deepthi Gupta is the mother of Arshi Gupta, India's youngest-ever national karting champion

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Rajasthan HC registry loses repeat offender's case file



A case file related to an accused repeat offender in a financial fraud case has gone missing from the Rajasthan High Court Registry, with the Supreme Court allowing the petitioner to seek an early hearing of the matter.

The Supreme Court, while hearing the case on August 10, did not interfere with the proceedings before the Rajasthan High Court and dismissed the special leave petition (SLP).

However, it allowed the petitioner to request an early hearing of the pending case before the High Court, according to the order.

The apex court, in its order, also said that if the records were not traceable in the High Court registry, the petitioner could approach the registrar general to have the records searched and placed before the High Court.

The case concerns Gyan Chand Agarwal and two other accused, who have approached the Rajasthan High Court seeking quashing of a case against them.

According to the petition filed before the Supreme Court, the records of the quashing petitions were found missing from the Criminal Branch of the Rajasthan High Court Registry on April 10. (PTI)

No HC relief for billboard at Abhishek Banerjee's office



The Calcutta High Court on Friday did not grant any interim order in a petition by the Trinamool Congress challenging the dismantling of an allegedly unauthorised billboard of the party at MP Abhishek Banerjee's office here.

Noting that the signboard at the 9, Camac Street premises in south Kolkata had already been removed by the KMC on Thursday, Justice Raja Basu Chowdhury said there is no scope for granting any interim protection on the issue at present.

"Though the petitioner would insist for restoration of the nameboard, I find that it is too premature to seek such a prayer. The same would tantamount to granting of a final relief at an interim stage which is not permissible in law," the court observed in its order.

On the petitioner's prayer for disclosure of the names of the KMC and police officials concerned, the court said that no order directing disclosure of particulars as sought can be passed.

Justice Basu Chowdhury also refused a prayer by the TMC for an order of injunction restraining the municipal authorities from taking any steps in respect of the premises at 9, Camac Street.

"It is also well settled that an order cannot be passed on the basis of mere apprehension," the court observed. (PTI)

CM Vijay seeks HC nod for bypolls to 5 vacant seats

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay on Friday approached the Madras High Court with a plea to vacate its interim order that restrained the EC from issuing any notification for by-election in respect of five constituencies, where the returned candidates resigned. Vijay stated this in his counter-affidavit filed in response to the Public Interest Litigation filed by advocat K Venkatachalapathy.

The constituencies included Tiruchirappalli (East) Assembly segment, one of the two seats from which Vijay won in the April 2026 elections and resigned later.

The First Bench comprising Chief Justice S A Dharmadhikari and Justice G Arul Murugan had on July 10 passed the interim order and directed Vijay, besides former AIADMK MLAs MR Vijayabaskar (Karur), C Vijayabaskar (Viralimalai), S.Jayakumar (Perundurai),



and Esaki Subbaiya from Ambasamudram to file their comprehensive counter-affidavits traversing all factual and legal assertions. They all had resigned as MLAs.

In his counter affidavit, Vijay sought to dismiss with exemplary cost, the PIL, which sought to declare that the vacancies arising out of the resignations of various returned candidates in the Assembly polls do not constitute "clear vacancies" or available vacancies for the purpose of holding bye-elections under Section 151-A of the Representation of the People Act, 1951 (RPA).



SC to hear Sumit Roy plea on August 31

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has listed for hearing on August 31 an appeal of Sumit Roy, personal assistant to Trinamool Congress MP Abhishek Banerjee, challenging the August 6 order of the Calcutta High Court denying him pre-arrest bail in the Salboni land-grabbing case.

The top court, which on August 6 stayed the arrest of Roy in connection with the land-grabbing case, has been supplied with some alleged incriminating materials in a sealed cover by the West Bengal police, who want to interrogate him in custody on the ground of non-cooperation.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state Government, had opposed the grant of protection from arrest by a bench comprising

Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana on August 19, the last date of hearing.

The law officer said that Roy was not cooperating in the ongoing probe in connection with the Salboni land-grabbing case, and added that the police needed to interrogate him in custody.

According to the apex court website, the bench is scheduled to hear Roy's plea on Monday.

On August 3, the Calcutta High Court had rejected Roy's anticipatory bail plea in the alleged Government land fraud case being investigated by the police.

The Solicitor General had urged the bench that the protection from arrest granted to Roy be withdrawn as he was allegedly not cooperating with the police and was evading questions.

Senior advocate Gopal



Sankaranarayanan, appearing for Roy, said that he has been appearing before the police as directed by the court and he has the right to maintain silence guaranteed under the Constitution. "The Constitution also secures the right to arrest (of the probe agency)," Justice Bagchi said.

The solicitor general pro-

vided materials collected so far by the police in a sealed cover to the bench. The CJ said that the matter will now be heard after he goes through the sealed cover report of the police.

The top court extended its August 6 order staying Roy's arrest in the case.

The case was registered under penal provisions relat-

Appellate court cannot enhance convict's sentence in absence of appeal on its own: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has said an appellate court cannot enhance the sentence of a convict on its own, in the absence of an appeal preferred by the State or the victim or the complainant.

The significant observation was made by the apex court in a sensational triple-murder case, in which a former vice-chancellor of the Calicut University, his wife and their security guard were killed.

A bench of Justices Manoj Misra and Vijay Bishnoi set aside a Madras High Court order that had enhanced the sentence of co-convict Gopi in the case from life imprisonment to a life term for the remainder of his life.

Life term refers to a sentence for the rest of a convict's natural life, but the duration can be reduced through remissions, whereas imprisonment for the "remainder of life" explicitly bars any early release or



reduction of sentence. In the case of a life-term convict, remission can only be granted after a period of 14 years in jail, according to Section 433A of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC).

The prosecution's case was that one Ambarasu, who was working as a driver for former vice-chancellor Malik Mohammed, was dismissed from service after he was caught in a fraudulent activity.

With a view to taking revenge, Ambarasu and his associate, Gopi, broke into Mohammed's house after

killing his watchman, Gnanaprakasam.

They killed Mohammed and escaped in his car with his wife, Katheerji Bibi.

The duo took Bibi to Ongoov village in Tamil Nadu's Villuppuram district and burnt her alive by pouring a mixture of petrol and diesel on her and setting her on fire. Police found her partially burnt body on November 14, 2007.

The trial court had granted the death penalty to Ambarasu and a life sentence to Gopi.

The high court, however,

enhanced Gopi's sentence from imprisonment for life to imprisonment for the remainder of his life.

The top court, in its judgment, said the high court had wrongly exercised its suo motu (on its own) revisional jurisdiction in enhancing Gopi's sentence when there was no appeal filed either by the State or the victim or the complainant seeking enhancement of the sentence, the appellate court cannot enhance the sentence of the convict on its own to leave the convict in a position worse off than he was before the filing of the appeal," the bench said.

"It is settled that in the absence of an appeal preferred by the State or the victim or the complainant seeking enhancement of the sentence, the appellate court cannot enhance the sentence of the convict on its own to leave the convict in a position worse off than he was before the filing of the appeal," the bench said.

The apex court also said the high court had erred in directing sentences to run consecutively.

"We, therefore, direct that the sentences would run concurrently," the bench said.

RG Kar case: HC seeks CBI report on alleged conspiracy

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

The Calcutta High Court on Friday directed the CBI to submit a report on the involvement of certain persons in an alleged conspiracy in the rape and murder of an on-duty doctor at RG Kar Medical College and Hospital here.

During a hearing, which was held in-camera, the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) filed a report on the progress of the probe into the matter before a division bench comprising Justices Shampa Sarkar and Tirthankar Ghosh.

A copy of the case diary



for the investigation was also placed before the bench, which the court directed to be retained in a sealed cover along with the progress report.

The court directed the additional solicitor general

(ASG), representing the central agency, to submit in a closed envelope "A report prepared by the CBI, indicating the path through which they have been able to locate the involvement of certain persons."

The division bench directed that the matter will be heard again on September 24.

The court had on May 21 ordered setting up of a three-member special investigation team of the CBI, headed by its joint director, East, to probe the developments from the time the R G Kar Medical College's trainee doctor had dinner on the ill-fated night of August 9, 2024, to her cremation.

Accused in Saif Ali Khan attack case seeks to plead guilty

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bangladeshi national arrested for allegedly stabbing actor Saif Ali Khan at his residence in Bandra in January 2025 approached a court here on Friday and sought to plead guilty in the case.

Mohammad Shariful Islam, arrested two days after the incident, is currently in judicial custody.

He filed an application expressing his willingness to plead guilty and sought leniency from the court, his lawyer Vipul Dushing said.

The court asked the prosecution to file its reply and



adjourned the hearing to September 11.

Earlier this month, additional sessions judge G P Deshmukh had framed charges against Islam,

paving the way for trial.

He was charged under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for 'robbery accompanied by the use of a deadly weapon', causing grievous hurt and house trespass as well as relevant sections of the Foreigners Act and Passport (Entry into India) Rules.

Khan was repeatedly stabbed with a knife by an intruder inside his 12th floor apartment in upscale Bandra on January 16, 2025.

The 54-year-old actor underwent an emergency surgery at the Lilavati Hospital and was discharged after five days.

TN minister Aadhav Arjuna seeks ₹1 crore damages from DMK chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

The Madras High Court on Friday ordered notice to former DMK president MK Stalin on a petition filed by Tamil Nadu PWD Minister Aadhav Arjuna, seeking ₹1 crore as damages/compensation for making defamatory statements against him.

Justice K Govindarajan Thilakavadi also ordered notice to the DMK Information Technology wing and posted it to September 15, for further hearing of the application arising out of a suit filed by Arjuna, which also sought to restrain Stalin and the DMK IT wing from publishing any similar false and defamatory statements concerning him.

In his application, the TVK leader submitted that the present suit was filed against Stalin and the DMK IT wing for publishing a false, mali-



cious and defamatory imputation against him through the official social media account of the DMK Information Technology Wing on the social media platform 'X', bearing the handle @DMKITwing, on June 8, 2026. The said publication has caused incalculable and grievous injury to the reputation, dignity, credibility and the public standing of the plaintiff.

Arjuna submitted that the impugned publication was not an isolated or unauthorised act of a mere social media functionary



but was published pursuant to the plan, directions, instructions and approval of Stalin, who exercises control, supervision and overarching authority over the affairs of the party, including its IT wing.

Stalin was therefore responsible for, and accountable in respect of, the publication and dissemination of the impugned post, and the DMK IT wing was directly responsible as the official operator and manager of the said X account through which the impugned post was published, he added.

He submitted that impugned statement was wholly false, fabricated, malicious and devoid of any factual basis whatsoever. An individual referred to in the Enforcement Directorate proceedings was not a relative, much less a close relative, of the plaintiff. The allegation has been published without any verification, without any supporting material, and in complete disregard of the truth, he added.

He said a person has lodged a formal complaint before the Commissioner of Police, Chennai, specifically stating that he was not the one being referred to in the context of the ED. Consequently, any attempt to portray the said individual as a relative of the Plaintiff (Arjuna), without undertaking even the most elementary verification, was manifestly reckless, grossly irresponsible and mala fide.

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BUSINESS11

IT stocks drive market rebound after 2-day slump

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty rebounded on Friday after two days of losses and ended higher, tracking buying in blue-chip IT stocks and a rally in global markets.

The 30-share BSE Sensex climbed 330.92 points, or 0.43 per cent, to settle at 77,264.51. During the day, it jumped 424.38 points, or 0.55 per cent, to 77,357.97.

The 50-share NSE Nifty settled 84.80 points, or 0.35 per cent, higher at 24,175.65.

Among the 30 Sensex firms, Tata Consultancy Services, Infosys, Tech Mahindra, HCL Tech, Titan and Eternal were the major winners.

ICICI Bank, UltraTech Cement, Asian Paints and ITC were among the laggards.

“Strong gains in IT stocks helped Indian equities close higher today. The sector was supported by Nvidia’s strong earnings and upbeat outlook, which reinforced optimism around sustained AI-related investments and benefited firms involved in enterprise AI deployment and work-flow integration.

“However, investor participation remained selective as markets awaited comments from the Fed Chair at the Jackson Hole symposium for greater clarity on the US interest-rate outlook and global liquidity conditions,” Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit

Investments Ltd, said.

According to Hariselman Radhakrishnan, Founder & CEO of HST Wealth, a Research Analyst firm, investors remained positive on IT stocks amid supportive

global cues for the sector.

“Indian equity benchmarks ended higher on Friday, snapping a two-session losing streak as strong gains in technology stocks offset subdued perfor-

mance across much of the broader market. Technology stocks were the session’s clear outperformers, with the Nifty IT index surging 3.5 per cent as investors responded positively to supportive global cues for the sector,” Radhakrishnan said.

The BSE MidCap Select index climbed 0.48 per cent and the SmallCap Select Index was marginally up by 0.02 per cent.

Among BSE sectoral indices, Focused IT surged 3.42 per cent, Information Technology jumped 3.32 per cent, PSU Bank 1.25 per cent, Bankex 1.01 per cent, MidSmall Private Banks 0.94 per cent and Metal 0.71 per cent.

Insurance, Consumer Durables, Energy, Realty,

Power and Oil & Gas were the laggards.

On the weekly front, the BSE benchmark declined 276.32 points, or 0.35 per cent, and the Nifty dipped 76.35 points, or 0.31 per cent.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dipped 0.17 per cent to \$89.63 per barrel.

In Asian markets, South Korea’s Kospi and Shanghai’s SSE Composite index ended lower, while Japan’s Nikkei 225 and Hong Kong’s Hang Seng index settled higher.

Markets in Europe were trading in positive territory. US markets ended higher on Thursday.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth ₹298.26 crore on Thursday, according to exchange data.

India needs to scale sustainability-aligned investments to meet climate goals: CII

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India needs to rapidly scale sustainability-aligned investments to meet the country’s climate and development goals, according to a CII report.

Key bottlenecks currently impede sustainable development in India, the CII India Sustainability Taskforce 2026 said.

The report said there are fragmented definitions of what counts as “sustainable” or “transition” activities, creating confusion for investors.

It noted that the quality of reported data requires further strengthening as current disclosures are evolving and dynamic.

The task force has recommended building a credible

carbon market and, where the government establishes a specifically designated GFI-linked public-revenue mechanism, creating a transparent financing pathway through the GFI (Green Finance Institution) for eligible climate and transition investment.

It has also recommended broadening proportionate, decision-useful sustainability reporting and enterprise

transition planning, beginning with larger, high-emitting and trade-exposed entities and expanding as reporting capacity matures.

The industry body Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) has constituted a high-level India Sustainability Taskforce to assist Indian enterprises on their sustainable development journey.

Crude oil futures fall nearly 1% to ₹7,915/barrel amid weak global cues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Crude oil prices fell nearly 1 per cent to ₹7,915 per barrel in futures trade on Friday, tracking weak trends in the international markets.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), crude futures for September delivery slipped ₹49, or nearly 1 per cent, to ₹7,915 per barrel.

The October contract also traded lower by ₹56, or 0.71 per cent, to ₹7,797 per barrel on the MCX.

Analysts said reports of a possible US role in Venezuela’s oil industry weighed on crude prices as market participants assessed the possibility of higher output from the

South American producer.

Talks have been spearheaded by US Secretary of State Marco Rubio and Venezuela’s acting president, Delcy Rodriguez, reports said.

The developments come even as the US-Iran conflict has disrupted global energy supplies and lifted prices.

The US Strategic Petroleum Reserve is also reportedly at a 40-year low, they added.

Globally, Brent oil futures for October delivery fell 1 per cent to trade at \$88.95 per barrel on the Intercontinental Exchange.

The West Texas Intermediate (WTI) crude futures for the same month contract also slipped nearly 1 per cent to \$83.02 per barrel on the New York Mercantile Exchange.

Brent crude is trading lower in the global markets as Washington has shifted from military to economic pressure, which has reduced fears of a wider war, Anindya Banerjee, Head of Commodity and Currency Research, Kotak Securities, said.

Over 77 lakh silver jewellery hallmarked with HUID number in 1 year

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Over 77 lakh silver jewellery and artefacts have been hallmarked with the HUID number since the six-digit number was introduced from September last year, with southern states leading in volumes, according to the Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS).

Silver hallmarking has been voluntary since October 2005, and from September 2025 onwards, hallmarked silver articles carry a six-digit Hallmark Unique Identification (HUID) number, enabling buyers to verify purity. “Since the launch of the Silver HUID portal on 1 September 2025, over 77 lakh silver jewellery pieces have already been hallmarked with HUID,” a BIS statement said. The number of silver jewellery articles hallmarked but without HUID number stood at 32 lakh in the 2024-25 fiscal year. Purity grades 925 and 800 account for nearly 95 per cent of all hallmarked items. After the introduction of HUID number, the silver hallmarking has been increasing.

According to the BIS, more than 25,000 silver jewellers have so far registered with BIS for hallmarking. Currently, there are 341 silver Assaying & Hallmarking Centres (AHCs) across 102 districts. Each hallmarked piece features the BIS Standard Mark, ‘SILVER’, purity grade, and the laser-marked six-digit alphanumeric Hallmark Unique Identification (HUID).

According to the BIS, the southern region leads the country in the volume of silver hallmarking, with 62 per cent, followed by the western region at 18 per cent and the central region at 10 per cent. Hallmarking provides consumers with third-party assurance of the purity or fineness of precious metal jewellery. Under the hallmarking scheme for silver jewellery and artefacts, silver jewellers are granted a Certificate of Registration in accordance with Indian Standard, IS 2112 ‘Silver and Silver alloys Jewellery and Artefacts – Fineness and Marking’ to sell hallmarked silver jewellery.

New technologies to enhance ease of doing work, create jobs, asserts VP Radhakrishnan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan on Friday said new technologies will enhance ease of doing work and help create more jobs.

While launching end-to-end sovereign AI stack for Indian enterprises and public institutions, Gnani Artha, the Vice President said concerns over job loss were raised when computers were introduced in the country, instead the IT industry has turned out to be the biggest job creator not only within the country but overseas as well.

He said that even many highly qualified people are raising concerns about

a reduction in jobs due to Artificial Intelligence.

“The more technology comes in, the more ease of work will come.

That will create more jobs. Bharat has undergone significant transformation in almost every sector, including AI, in the past 12 years,” he said.

Radhakrishnan said reverse migration has started taking place now. People are coming back to the country and bringing new technologies that they have learnt over the years.

Digital Sansad has started using AI to translate Parliamentary debates and papers available in multiple Indian languages, he said, adding that AI has tremendous scope.

Talking about Gnani Artha, Radhakrishnan said it is a part of a larger national journey towards self-reliance.

India’s tyre exports rise 16% in Q1 to ₹7,700 crore despite global headwinds, says ATMA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Tyre exports from India grew 16 per cent year-on-year to ₹7,700 crore during the June quarter, despite geopolitical uncertainty, supply-chain disruptions and elevated input and logistics costs, the Automotive Tyre Manufacturers’ Association (ATMA) said on Friday.

Citing data released by the Ministry of Commerce, Government of India, the Association, said the strong performance during April-June 2026 builds on the industry’s record export value of ₹27,312 crore achieved in FY2025-26.

Improved market access

through trade agreements and supportive export policies can enable the industry to build on this momentum and further strengthen India’s position as a global tyre manufacturing and export hub, ATMA stated.

Passenger Car Radial (PCR) tyres registered notable growth, with exports increasing 21 per cent in value terms

during the quarter, the Association said.

ATMA Chairman Arun Mammen said, “The significant growth in tyre exports during the first quarter represents a strong start to the new financial year.

It reflects the growing acceptance of Indian-manufactured tyres across discerning global markets and

the sustained investments made by the industry in technology, capacity, product development and quality.”

Europe emerged as a major growth driver, with tyre exports to the region increasing 25 per cent to Rs 3,003 crore during Q1. The region accounted for nearly 40 per cent of India’s total tyre exports.

The US continued to be the single-largest export destination, accounting for 16 per cent of the total export value during the quarter. Indian-manufactured tyres are currently exported to more than 170 countries. India’s global tyre footprint also extends beyond direct tyre exports.

Sandhya Devanathan exits Meta after a decade to join OpenAI as VP South East Asia, Australia

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Meta’s Vice President and Head for India and South East Asia, Sandhya Devanathan, is leaving the social media giant after more than a decade and is all set to join OpenAI as Vice President for South East Asia and Australia.

In this newly-created role, Devanathan will be OpenAI’s most senior leader in South East Asia and Australia, with responsibility for its performance across consumer growth, enterprise adoption and partnerships, regulatory

engagement and operations.

The Meta veteran penned an emotional post on LinkedIn, announcing her departure from the social media giant and said she is looking forward to her “next exciting chapter”. She, however, did not divulge her next move.

OpenAI, though, confirmed that Devanathan will join as Vice President for Southeast Asia and Australia. She will be based in Singapore and report to Kiran Mani, OpenAI’s Managing Director for Asia Pacific, the ChatGPT maker confirmed. Devanathan’s joining date at OpenAI could

not be immediately ascertained. Notably, the appointment comes as OpenAI expands its presence across Asia Pacific amid growing adoption of its AI tools among consumers, enterprises and developers.

Over the past two years, OpenAI has opened local offices in Singapore, Tokyo, Seoul, Sydney and Delhi, and expanded its regional leadership team with the recent appointment of Kiran Mani as Managing Director for APAC.

In June this year, the Sam Altman-led company announced the appointment of Prabhjeet Singh as

Managing Director for India – among its top-priority markets and one where the company has been stepping up investments and expanding its footprint.

In fact, OpenAI has been

moving its India strategy to top gear through partnerships with enterprises and developers, while strengthening engagement with policymakers. The company opened its first office in New

Delhi in November 2025.

Altman himself has repeatedly described India as one of OpenAI’s key markets and has praised the country’s rapid AI uptake and commitment to investing across the tech stack.

Devanathan brings more than 25 years of experience across the technology and financial services sectors. She joined Meta in 2016 and held several leadership roles across the region, including leading its Asia Pacific gaming business and helping expand the company’s presence in Singapore and Vietnam.

In the LinkedIn post,

Devanathan described the decision to leave after more than a decade as “bittersweet” and said she would take a short break before beginning her “next exciting chapter”. Looking back at her tenure, she highlighted Meta’s work with businesses, startups and creators across the region, including government citizen services on WhatsApp in India and helping small businesses establish storefronts on its apps in Vietnam, Indonesia and Thailand.

“I joined Meta when we had just about 300 employees in Singapore,” she

recounted and reflected on how the landscape looked “so different” in 2016, with everyone talking about digital transformation.

“And we were right in the midst of it – helping startups, companies, creators and the ecosystem grow across the region while delivering great experiences for hundreds of millions of our users,” she wrote. Devanathan said she was “incredibly proud” of what her teams had built and thanked colleagues, businesses, ecosystem partners, non-profits and creators she had worked with during her time at Meta.

Xi chairs high-level review of Nepal-Tibet flood rescue

KJM VARMA ■ Beijing

Chinese President Xi Jinping on Friday chaired the ruling Communist Party meeting to take stock of the grim situation arising out of the massive flash floods engulfing the Tibet-Nepal border in which hundreds were killed and many remain missing.

The meeting was to deliberate and make arrangements on rescue and relief efforts after the flash floods hit Gyirong County in the Tibet Autonomous Region on Wednesday.

At the beginning of the meeting, Xi and other leaders observed a moment of silence to mourn the victims of the disaster, state-run Xinhua news agency reported. Officials at the meeting said that emergency rescue operations have been carried out swiftly and in a well-coordinated manner, with comprehensive efforts underway to resettle affected people.

At the meeting, it was decided that search and rescue plans should be formulated scientifically, and all efforts should be made to search for and rescue all missing Chinese and foreign nationals, according to the report. The death toll of the flash floods in Nepal has reached 469, while three people were killed in Tibet. Over 550 people were reported missing in Tibet and 100



Chinese Premier Li Qiang, fifth from left, inspects a mudslide-hit area in Gyirong County in Xigaze, southwestern China's Tibet Autonomous Region

Chinese were yet to be traced in Nepal. According to Chinese officials, around 1,000 people, including 555 tourists, were evacuated to safety. Officials are yet to provide details about the nationalities of the tourists. A number of Indian pilgrims on Kailash Mansarovar Yatra were reportedly stranded following the floods.

Meanwhile, China has sounded a Level-IV alert following the flash floods, warning that a newly formed barrier lake at the confluence of two rivers faces a high risk of breaching and flooding downstream areas.

China's Ministry of Water Resources on Thursday night sounded an emergency in Tibet, cautioning of a threat

posed by the barrier lake, which formed near the confluence of Chhochhen Khola and Purepu Tsangpo rivers.

These rivers originate in Tibet and flow into Nepal as part of the Bhotekoshi river system. China's emergency response system for natural disasters has four levels, with Level-I being the highest and Level IV the lowest.



This satellite image provided by Vantor shows Syapru Besi, Nepal on October 18, 2023



This satellite image provided by Vantor shows destruction at Syapru Besi, Nepal on Thursday, August 27, 2026, after the flash flood

Devotees, family members of victims offer prayers at Mahakaal temple in Kathmandu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kathmandu

Devotees, priests and family members of many who have been affected by the devastating flash floods in Nepal on Friday offered prayers at the Mahakaal Shani Bhagwan Temple in Kathmandu for the repose of the souls of persons who have lost their lives in the tragedy.

On Friday also marks an auspicious day of Shravan Purnima, and coincides with the festival of Raksha Bandhan.

Massive flash floods originating from Tibet swept through central Nepal, razing down several towns and villages, washing away critical bridges and crippling a dozen hydropower projects as it gushed downstream, affecting multiple districts. As the Himalayan nation continued to grapple with the aftermath of the disaster, a sombre mood prevailed at the



Security personnel carry people to safer locations after authorities issued a fresh flood warning following a rise in water levels in areas affected by a devastating flash flood earlier this week in Dhading district, Nepal

Mahakaal Shani Bhagwan Temple. Devotees and family members of many who have been affected by the calamity offered prayers for those who have lost their lives and for the safe return of those who remain missing.

Suresh, a priest, said, "This temple is specifically a Mahakaal Temple. People come here to offer prayers for their family and for protection from any difficulties or bad times they may be going through.

At present, those who lost their lives in the landslide are being remembered, and prayers are being offered for peace for their souls.

"We are also praying for the well-being and safety of those who survived. That is why people have come here to perform puja and offer prayers," he told PTI Videos. Several devotees milled around at the old temple and also prayed for the safety and well-

being of people and the speedy recovery of the injured.

Govind Singh, a devotee, said, "This is the Mahakaal Temple of Bhairavnath.

We are deeply saddened by the flood in Rasuwa. We pray to God for all those who have lost their lives and pray that they find peace and a place in heaven."

Several families still have no information about the whereabouts of their loved ones, even as they continue their search, anxiously waiting at hospitals to hear some news about them.

At Tribhuvan University Teaching Hospital in Maharajgunj and at Bharatpur Hospital in Chitwan, many families continued to search for relatives as authorities dealt with a growing number of bodies recovered from the Trishuli and Narayani rivers.

Thakur Prasad Kandel and Lilawati Sapkota were among those at the hospital on Thursday

who were looking for their brothers missing since Wednesday morning. Other families at the hospitals were facing similar uncertainty, as relatives tried to establish whether those missing had survived, been rescued or were among the bodies recovered from the rivers.

Shibha Shakya, another devotee at the Mahakaal Shani Bhagwan Temple, said, "If God has so much power, we pray to Him to give everyone peace and protect everyone. Many people, including people from my own district, are still trapped."

"Many of them have not been able to make contact yet. We pray that God protects them and keeps them safe.

"They have still not been able to contact their families. We pray to God to bring them back safely and that we receive good news that they are safe and sound," Shakya said. Balram Thapa,

another devotee, said, "There is a trauma centre hospital ahead and there is also a temple here. The massive flood in Rasuwa has caused a lot of damage. People from my district, Rolpa, as well as many others across Nepal have suffered heavy losses." Around 20 people from his district are still stranded there, he said.

"But we have not received any information about them yet. I am searching for them at the hospital as well, and I am also praying for them at the temple.

At present, the people of Nepal are going through a lot of pain and suffering and I am also going through this difficult time," Thapa said.

The death toll from flash floods in central Nepal rose to 538 on Friday as search and rescue operations continued for a third day, with nearly 1,000 people still missing in the Himalayan nation. (PTI)

No foreign rescue teams, keeps aid channel open, says Nepal

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Nepal has decided to keep foreign search-and-rescue teams away from its flood-ravaged areas, even as India, China and several other countries have offered personnel and specialised equipment to help locate hundreds of missing people.

The decision is striking because the disaster has also affected Nationals of several countries. As many as over 517 foreign nationals are still reported missing, including citizens of India, China, the US, Malaysia, Ukraine, the UK, Australia and Canada.

Kathmandu, however, believes the immediate rescue effort can be handled by its own security forces. The Nepalese Government's position is not a rejection of international assistance. Rather, it is an attempt to ensure that the rescue operation remains under a single domestic command while



foreign Governments contribute through relief supplies, financial support and, where necessary, specialised technical assistance.

The 2015 earthquake still weighs on Kathmandu

One of the strongest arguments behind the decision comes from Nepal's experience during the 2015 earthquake. The massive international response brought search-and-rescue teams from several countries into Nepal. While the foreign assistance was substantial,

coordinating numerous teams, agencies and equipment proved difficult for the authorities.

Nepal does not want those coordination problems repeated during the present emergency.

The Nepal Army and police have reportedly advised the Government that domestic agencies have the capacity to lead the search operation. Kathmandu has consequently chosen a centralised model in which the country's own security agencies remain responsible for rescue and recovery. Foreign Minister Shishir Khanal has made clear, however, that Nepal could seek outside technical assistance if rescuers confront challenges requiring expertise or equipment that is not readily available domestically.

This could include difficult operations involving tunnels, collapsed structures or other technically demanding sites.

India ready with NDRF

India has offered to deploy teams of the National Disaster Response Force, along with equipment that could support the search and rescue effort.

New Delhi is still waiting for Kathmandu to respond to the offer. "We stand ready to offer any assistance that the Nepal authorities might require," External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said on Friday. India has meanwhile moved ahead with humanitarian assistance. More than 47.5 tonnes of relief material, including medicines and food packets, have been sent to Nepal. New Delhi has also offered Bailey bridges and prefabricated truss bridges to help reconnect areas where flood damage has disrupted transport links. The Indian offer has an added urgency as Indian nationals constitute a significant portion of those whose

whereabouts remain unknown.

China and other nations also offered help

China too sought to send assistance, while other countries offered similar support.

The United States and the United Kingdom have offered financial and humanitarian assistance. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said Washington was prepared to provide humanitarian support. The UK has also been monitoring the situation involving its citizens and seeking information about those affected.

International financial institutions have also stepped in. The World Bank has announced support, while the Asian Development Bank is looking at longer-term assistance aimed at strengthening Nepal's disaster preparedness, early-warning systems and infrastructure against future emergencies.

Kathmandu wants one channel for aid

Nepal's preference for centralised coordination extends to financial assistance. Foreign contributions are being encouraged through the Prime Minister's Relief Fund, allowing the Government to maintain oversight of incoming aid and its distribution.

The reasoning is straightforward. Multiple foreign rescue teams operating simultaneously could mean more demands on local authorities for transport, accommodation, security and logistics. A centralised aid system, by contrast, gives Kathmandu greater control over how resources are allocated.

The foreign ministry has also created an Emergency Response Team to coordinate information on foreign nationals caught up in the disaster.

Iran's "confidence has grown over the months that it cannot only survive, but it can prevail, it can reset the regional landscape."

In the runup to the war, the Islamic Republic appeared more vulnerable than at any point since Saddam Hussein's Iraq invaded in 1980. Iran's currency had cratered, setting off some of the biggest anti-government protests in its history, which were brutally suppressed in January, with thousands killed. (AP)

PML-N's Iftikhar Gillani elected as PoK PM

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Barrister Iftikhar Ali Gillani was on Friday elected to the so-called post of prime minister of Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) following recent elections marred by violent protests and allegations of massive rigging.

Gillani, of the ruling Pakistan Muslim League Nawaz (PML-N), secured 30 of the 44 votes in the so-called legislative assembly during its session in Muzaffarabad, the region's capital.

His challenger, Mukhtar Ahmed of the Pakistan Peoples Party (PPP), secured 14 votes. The assembly comprises 53 members, but its present strength is 46 because elections for seven seats in Poonch and Sudhnoti districts have yet to be held due to what authorities described as a law and order situation.

Only 44 lawmakers participated in the voting on Friday as the speaker did not cast his vote while PML-N regional president Shah Ghulam Qadir skipped the assembly session due to differences with his party.

PML-N supremo Nawaz Sharif on Thursday nominated Gillani for the so-called post of prime minister.

The polls in the region's so-called legislative assembly were held in three phases on July 27, August 2 and August 3 and were marred by violent protests and allegations of rigging.

Gillani was defeated from a seat he contested directly but later elected to the leg-



islative assembly on a technocrat seat. Out of 53 seats in the PoK legislative assembly, 45 are directly elected, while eight are reserved for women, technocrats and clerics.

The PML-N has so far won 25 seats of the direct elections to 38 constituencies, and the PPP has won 12. The Awami Dast-o-Bazu party won one seat and supported the PML-N. Out of eight reserved seats, PML-N got six and the PPP two.

A large number of people under the banner of the Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC) have been holding protests in PoK since early June, in which several protesters and security officials were killed. The regional government banned the group in June. The JAAC has been protesting against the 12 seats reserved for refugees, and the election of Gillani may add fuel to the fire as he was elected on a reserved seat after facing defeat on a general seat. (PTI)

Six months on, war changed West Asia, but not as its architects hoped

JOSEPH KRAUSS ■ Dubai

It's been six months since the United States and Israel attacked Iran with the perennial goal of transforming the Middle East through military force. The region has changed, but not in the way they had hoped.

The Islamic Republic survived the assassination of its top leaders and weeks of heavy bombing, and found a potent form of leverage in the Strait of Hormuz. Gulf Arab nations saw worrying



gaps open up in the American security umbrella they have relied on for decades - and some are looking at alternatives.

Israel has once again thrashed its enemies without defeating them, and after nearly three years of war in Gaza and new land seizures, is at risk of a generational rupture with the US, its closest ally. Hopes of normalising relations with Saudi Arabia - another enduring US and Israeli aspiration - have dimmed even further.

When they attacked Iran on February 28, the US and Israel hoped to topple its clerical leadership and replace it with a pro-Western Government.

Instead, they've ended up with a "hardened and very radical regime," said Barbara Leaf, a former ambassador who served as assistant secretary of state for the West Asia in the Biden administration. "That is going to be exceptionally difficult to deal with, to say the least," she said.

US, South Korea, Japan to hold military drill

HYUNG-JIN KIM ■ Seoul

South Korea, the US and Japan will go ahead with a trilateral military drill next month to better deal with North Korean nuclear threats, officials in Seoul said Friday, a day after North Korea vowed to retaliate against what it called US hostilities.

The development further dims prospects for an early resumption of diplomacy between North Korea and the US, despite President Donald Trump's recent decision to scale back a major bilateral military drill with South Korea in an apparent goodwill gesture toward the North. South Korea's military said in a statement the



Freedom Edge exercise will start on September 7 for a five-day run in the waters off South Korea's southern Jeju Island.

It said the exercise is defensive in nature and meant to respond to North Korean nuclear and missile threats as well as promote

regional peace and stability.

North Korea has previously slammed the trilateral drill as a "reckless show of strength" that showed its adversaries' confrontational stance against it. Pyongyang has also said the drill contained a US intention to lay siege to China and exert pres-

sure on Russia. The Freedom Edge drill, a US-South Korea-Japan exercise, was launched in 2024. It's designed to increase the sophistication of previous exercises with simultaneous air and naval drills geared toward improving joint ballistic missile defence, anti-submarine warfare, surveillance and other skills and capabilities.

Last week, the US and South Korean militaries ended their annual Ulchi Freedom Shield exercise six days earlier than originally planned, after Trump said he had ordered the Pentagon to "substantially reduce" the drill that North Korea views as an invasion rehearsal. Trump cited what he described as a good relation-

ship with North Korean leader Kim Jong Un.

But North Korea rebuffed Trump's overture, saying just shortening the drill won't change its "provocative, aggressive nature." North Korea launched about 10 short-range ballistic missiles toward the sea, apparently delivering on its previous threat to respond to the US-South Korean drill. Pyongyang has previously said it won't resume diplomacy with the US unless it drops its demand for a North Korean denuclearisation as a precondition for talks.

Since his earlier diplomacy with Trump collapsed in 2019, Kim has boosted his military and diplomatic credentials by enlarging his

nuclear arsenal and aligning with Russia over its war against Ukraine.

With greater leverage now, experts say Kim would likely aim to win big US concessions like an international recognition of North Korea as a nuclear state and sweeping sanctions relief in return for a partial surrender of his nuclear arsenal.

On Thursday, North Korea's Foreign Ministry accused the US of engaging in "a series of hostile moves" targeting the North, including a possible sale of air-to-air missiles and related equipment to South Korea. It said North Korea "will make a serious, immediate and powerful response to the hostile acts in different spheres." (AP)

Zambia Opposition leader detained for treason



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Lusaka

Police in Zambia detained the country's main opposition leader Thursday over alleged treason after he handed himself over for questioning after having sought refuge at a United Nations building following a disputed election two weeks ago.

Brian Mundubile, who challenged President Hakainde Hichilema in the Aug 13 election, surrendered to police alongside his running mate, Makebi Zulu.

They both recorded "warn and caution statements," according to police – a procedure that normally comes before formal charges are filed. They are being held in custody, police said in a statement. Hichilema was

declared the winner of an unusually troubled presidential election in the copper-rich southern African nation that has a history of largely peaceful votes. Hichilema is expected to be inaugurated for a second five-year term next week.

Mundubile has rejected the result, claiming irregularities in the vote. He said he went into hiding after disputing the election results in fear for his life. The treason allegations against Mundubile and Zulu follow a raid by security forces at Mundubile's home a day after the election.

Authorities said 11 people were arrested in the raid and AK-47 assault rifles and other military equipment were found at the property.

Russian drones batter Ukraine's Kyiv region

HANNA ARHIROVA/
BARRY HATTON ■ Kyiv

Russian forces on Friday resumed their drone barrage of Ukraine's Kyiv region, hitting more than a dozen apartment buildings and storage depots in a second straight day of aerial attacks, officials said.

Prolonged air raids in Kyiv on Thursday essentially locked down the Ukrainian capital for 15 hours, the Foreign Ministry said, choking the economy and severely disrupting civilian life more than four years after Russia's full-scale invasion of its neighborhood. Even longer alerts are a daily reality in regions closer to the front line, the ministry said.

Russian drone and missile attacks are also aiming at the power grid in what Ukrainian officials say is an annual campaign to "weaponise winter." In Ukraine's southern Kherson region on the Black Sea, where glide bombs a day earlier forced a combined heat and power plant to shut down, officials predicted a winter of extended outages and told people to move elsewhere if they could.

Russian strikes in the Kyiv region damaged 14 warehouses, 16 private houses, three apartment buildings and 16 vehicles, Tymur Tkachenko, head of the Kyiv regional military administration, said Friday. A second drone hit one location after emergency crews were deployed, the State Emergency Service said, in what is termed by the mil-



itary as a "double tap" that targets first responders.

The attacks killed one person and wounded two others, according to officials.

The Russian Defence Ministry said its forces overnight struck a warehouse in the Kyiv region that stores Ukraine's Flamingo cruise missiles and fuel for rocket boosters.

Ukrainian officials did not immediately confirm the Russian claim, and The Associated Press could not verify it. Recent strikes have damaged numerous warehouses across Kyiv and the wider region, including facilities storing books, food and other consumer goods.

The attacks stretched into daylight hours, and Tkachenko urged residents to stay in safe locations and heed air raid alerts.

Russia is launching small numbers of fast-moving jet-powered drones in waves in an attempt to paralyse the capital, according to Andrii Kovalenko, head of Ukraine's Centre for Countering Disinformation at the National Security and Defence Council. (AP)

Judge again blocks Trump mail ballot executive order

NICHOLAS RICCARDI
■ Washington

A federal judge on Thursday halted — at least for now — attempts to implement President Donald Trump's executive order limiting mail voting.

The move stalled the directive for a second time only about a week before the first mail ballots are due to be sent out for the rapidly approaching midterm elections. US District Court Judge Indira Talwani blocked the Government from implementing the order for two weeks. The case could soon be appealed back to the Supreme Court, days after the justices handed down a



procedural decision lifting an earlier ruling of Talwani's that had blocked Trump's order from taking effect.

The ruling Thursday came after Democrats and voting rights groups refilled their lawsuits to comply with the recent Supreme Court deci-

sion. The high court's conservative majority did not rule on the legality of Trump's executive order, instead saying the legal challenges against it that led Talwani to initially freeze it were filed too soon.

Now the administration

has issued a formal rule governing whether the US Postal Service will deliver states' mail ballots, effectively restarting the legal fight. The Postal Service says it won't deliver mail ballots unless states provide a list of voters who should receive them and format the envelopes in a certain way. "Plaintiff states have neither time nor funds to design new mail ballots, seek approval of the new designs, order production of mail ballots, update their own election management systems, train election officials to use the USPS portal and upload citizen data to the portal, all before the midterms," Talwani wrote on Thursday. (AP)

US attempt to showcase dominance over Canada through wildlife image backfires

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

Amid a raging trade war, the White House's attempt at one-upmanship against Canada appeared to have backfired when online users pointed out that the photograph of a bald eagle strangling a Canada goose had the opposite outcome.

The photograph taken by an immigrant from Goa, Mervyn Sequeira, who has since settled in Canada, became a talking point on social media when the White House posted it on its X account on Wednesday, signifying American dominance over its northern neighbour.

The image was part of a series of photographs taken by Sequeira last year in Burlington, Ontario.

The photographs show the Canada



goose fighting back, forcing the bald eagle — the American national bird - to abandon the fight.

The Canada goose, native to North America and widely associated with Canada, is one of the country's most recognisable cultural symbols. The full set of photographs from the 20-

minute fight shows the bald eagle launching multiple attacks against the Canada goose, which at several times appears pinned to the ice and in danger of being killed.

"There were moments when we thought it was over for the goose," Sequeira said when describing the encounter to CBC News in 2025. But the bird survived after resisting repeated attacks.

"It was like boxers in a ring," Sequeira said last year, calling the matchup "very symbolic in the political context."

In February, when the US men's hockey team beat Canada to take the gold medal at the Winter Olympics, the White House used the same eagle/goose image it used this week to signify American dominance. (PTI)

1 killed, 9 injured in blast in Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Peshawar

At least one person was killed, and nine others sustained injuries in an explosion on Friday in northwest Pakistan, police said.

According to the police, the incident occurred in the Makeen bazaar area of South Waziristan district in the restive Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province. A man associated with the local peace committee was killed, and nine others were injured after an improvised explosive device attached to a motorcycle exploded in the busy marketplace, police said, adding that several shops nearby were also damaged due to the explosion.

No individual or group has



immediately claimed responsibility for the attack.

The injured were taken to the nearby hospital.

Following the explosion, police registered a preliminary report, cordoned off the area and launched a search operation.

On Wednesday, a police official and a local peace

committee member were killed in a targeted attack in the Sararogha tehsil of Upper South Waziristan.

The Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province has faced recurring unrest over the years driven by militant violence, cross-border movement of fighters from Afghanistan and repeated military operations.

Drone strikes kill 8 civilians in Sudan

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Cairo

Drone strikes have killed eight civilians and wounded dozens in Sudan's Kordofan region, a rights group said on Friday.

Emergency Lawyers, an independent group documenting atrocities in Sudan, said a drone targeted a group of civilians travelling on Thursday in the desert town of Sowdari in North Kordofan state. As others rushed to help the victims, a second drone struck, the group said.

The group said in a statement posted on Facebook that targeting civilians and then attacking again while they were being rescued amounts to a violation of international humanitarian law and is a war crime. It



called for an independent investigation to determine who was responsible. Sudan plunged into all-out war in April 2023 as fighting erupted between the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces and the Sudanese military. The conflict has killed at least 59,000 people, according to Armed Conflict Location & Event Data, a conflict monitoring group.

Drone warfare has become a defining feature in the country's war, with both sides carrying out strikes. Drone strikes are now the leading cause of death in Sudan, according to the United Nations, accounting for 80 per cent of civilian deaths during the first four months of 2026.

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Indian SMEs aim for global footprint at Singapore exhibition



GURDIP SINGH ■ Singapore

Indian innovation-driving Small and Medium Enterprises (SMEs) are increasingly creating intellectual property, technology platforms, digital products and new business models that can compete internationally, says Neel Sinha, Founder and CEO of nFactor, which operates out of Bengaluru with Singapore as its international office.

Sinha was speaking on the sidelines of 'The Business Show Asia' exhibition in Singapore on August 26-27.

"Make in India explicitly places innovation and entrepreneurship alongside investment and infrastructure, while Startup India provides mechanisms to help recognised startups access benefits, intellectual-property support and pathways to scale," he said as his SME firm showcased its flagship gamification product Playly at the Singapore exhibition. (PTI)

Norway's King Harald V dies at 89, his son becomes King Haakon VIII

MARK LEWIS ■ Stavanger

King Harald V of Norway, who went into exile in the United States as a child during the Nazi occupation of his homeland and refused a string of potential brides from the European nobility so he could marry his school sweetheart, died on Friday. He was 89.

The palace said he died at the National Hospital in Oslo at 6.35 am. Harald was Europe's oldest monarch. The popular king modernised the royal house but refused to follow in the footsteps of other ageing monarchs who have abdicated in recent times. His son automatically became King Haakon VIII. Like other



Norway's King Harald gives a speech during a gala dinner at the Palace in connection with the state visit of the Icelandic presidential couple, in Oslo, on April 8, 2025. FILE PHOTO

royal houses in Europe, the Norwegian monarchs serve a largely symbolic role, enjoying celebrity status while real power in the democracy of 5.5 million rests with an elected parliament.

Harald was crowned after his British-born father, King Olav V, died in January 1991, and reigned during an oil-and-gas-driven economic boom in his country.

"A whole nation is in mourning, and the people of Norway are left with a deep sense of gratitude for a long life in the service of Norway," Prime Minister Jonas Gahr Store said in a statement. "For more than three decades as monarch, Harald V demonstrated an unwaver-

ing faith in the Norwegian people. He helped us to see the best in ourselves — and in one another."

Harald was born in 1937 in Asker, near Oslo, becoming the first Norwegian prince to be born in the country since King Olav IV in 1370. In the following centuries, Norway didn't have a king of its own until Harald's grandfather, Haakon VII, was elected king following the 1905 dissolution of the union between Sweden and Norway.

Harald was 3 years old when the Nazis occupied Norway at the start of World War II. To avoid capture, his mother fled with him and his sisters, Ragnhild and Astrid, first to Sweden and then by

boat to the US, while Harald's father and grandfather went into exile in Britain with Norway's Government.

Haakon's refusal to go along with German demands garnered respect among his people. During their time in the US, the Norwegian royals were often guests at the White House. Harald was 6 when he carried out his first official duty, christening new warplanes at a Norwegian air base in Canada.

The family was reunited in Norway in June 1945, shortly after the end of the war in Europe. Harald attended public schools, the Norwegian military college and Oxford University. Like his father — an Olympic

champion sailor in 1928 — Harald loved the sea and sailboats. He represented Norway at several Olympics. As a young man, Harald was urged to find a bride among Europe's noblemen and princesses. For nine years he shunned a series of prospects, holding out until he finally won his father's permission to marry his school sweetheart, Sonja Haraldsen, the daughter of a successful businessman.

King Olav had feared the marriage would weaken Norway's still-young monarchy. Instead, Norwegians greeted the August 29, 1968, wedding with jubilation, and later embraced Sonja as their queen. (AP)

NBCC, NHPC sign MoU for pan-India execution of infrastructure projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

NBCC (India) Limited, a Navratna CPSE under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, Government of India and NHPC Limited, a Navratna CPSE under the Ministry of Power, Government of India, have entered into a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) for the execution of NHPC's infrastructure projects, primarily comprising buildings, structures and allied works, on a pan-India basis.

The MoU was formalised on 28th August 2026 at NHPC's corporate office, Faridabad, marking a significant step towards strengthening cooperation between the two leading Navratna CPSEs for the development of modern, robust and sustainable infrastructure across the country.

The MoU was signed by Deepak Kumar, general manager (Civil), NHPC, and Rajeev Kumar, chief general manager (Engineering), NBCC, in the presence of senior officials from both organisations. The NBCC delegation included KP Mahadevaswamy, CMD, Anjeev Jain, director (Finance), Vijay Kumar Choudhary, senior ED (Finance), and senior officials from SBG Delhi-II. From NHPC, Bhupender Gupta, CMD, Sanjay Kumar Singh, director (Projects), Suprakash Adhikari, director (Technical), Mahesh Kumar Sharma, director

(Finance), RS Ranpara, director (Personnel), and RT Nathan, executive director (HR) were present.

Under the MoU, NBCC will provide Project Management Consultancy (PMC) services and undertake specific NHPC infrastructure projects on a deposit work basis. The scope includes design, engineering, project management, procurement, construction, quality control, installation, commissioning and statutory compliances, along with handing over of completed projects.

The partnership brings together the complementary strengths of the two organisations. While NHPC brings extensive experience in the hydropower and clean power sectors, NBCC contributes its established expertise in planning and execution of diverse infrastructure projects in accordance with Government guidelines. The collaboration is expected to facilitate standardised and efficient execution of NHPC's infrastructure projects across India, including residential blocks, residential/commercial infrastructure, office complexes and allied facilities, with emphasis on cost-effectiveness, time-efficiency and requisite quality standards.

The MoU marks another important step in strengthening inter-CPSE cooperation and creating a structured framework for delivering efficient, sustainable and future-ready infrastructure across India.



Airtel adds 26.8 lakh mobile users in July, Jio 24.4 lakh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Bharti Airtel led the industry's July mobile subscriber growth with 26.8 lakh net additions, while India's largest telecom operator Reliance Jio, gained 24.4 lakh new users, sector regulator TRAI's monthly subscription data showed on Friday.

Vodafone Idea, too, added mobile users — its net adds stood at 2.4 lakh for July. State-owned Bharat Sanchar Nigam Ltd (BSNL) posted an increase of 1.68 lakh wireless subscribers during the month.

During July 2026, the



Indian wireless market expanded by 55.38 lakh mobile subscribers — its base surged to 128.79 crore by the end of July, up from 128.23 crore from the previous month.

"As per the information

received from 1,562 operators for the month of July 2026, the total number of broadband subscribers increased from 1087.50 million (108.75 crore) at the end of June 2026 to 1094.48 million (109.44 crore) at the

end of July 2026 with a monthly growth rate of 0.64 per cent," the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India said in its latest report on subscriber count.

For Bharti Airtel, net additions of 26.88 lakh mobile subscribers pushed its wireless subscriber base to 48.94 crore in July. Reliance Jio added 24.46 lakh mobile users in July, taking its total subscriber tally of wireless users to 50.60 crore.

Vodafone Idea saw its mobile subscriber base rise to 19.90 crore in July, after gaining 2.40 lakh wireless subscribers during the month.

Indian Bank eyes ₹1,000-₹1,500 crore treasury income in FY27

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chennai

Public sector lender Indian Bank is looking to mobilise treasury income of ₹1,000-₹1,500 crore in the current financial year, following better-than-expected first-quarter realisation.

During the first quarter, the bank anticipated an overall treasury income of ₹300 crore, but actually earned ₹500 crore, much better than expected, Indian Bank MD and CEO Binod Kumar told PTI in an interaction.

Overall, he said, "We anticipate treasury income between ₹1,000 crore and ₹1,500 crore during the current financial year".

Treasury income comes from two components. The first is trading income, and the other is the interest income from investments.

Asked about asset quality management, Kumar said the bank has been managing it quite well.

The bank aims to bring down gross non-performing assets (NPAs) to 1.5-1.6 per cent of the total advances and Net NPAs to 0.15-0.2 per cent by the end of the



current financial year. Besides, he said, the bank would undertake the sale of ₹200 crore in bad loans to an asset reconstruction company (ARC) during the current financial year.

On the asset side, Kumar said the lender expects its gold loan book to cross ₹1.5 lakh crore in the current financial year, supported by robust demand. "Gold loan is safe lending for banks...it is not a consumption loan, but mostly it is income-generating and also helps small businesses to grow."

"Last year, we saw very significant growth of 30 per cent in the segment due to a jump in gold prices. It will be slower this year as there is a 30 per cent decline in

gold prices," Kumar said.

This growth would come from tonnage, he said, adding that the gold loan segment is likely to grow about 20 per cent.

Currently, the gold loan portfolio is around ₹1.25 lakh crore, and the book should exceed ₹1.5 lakh crore during this financial year at the anticipated growth rate, he said. Kumar further said that RAM (Retail, Agriculture, and MSME) constitutes 65 per cent of the overall loan book while the remaining 35 per cent is from corporate.

The bank wants to maintain the ratio going forward, he said, adding that RAM has huge capacity for growth with a lot of opportunity in agriculture and MSMEs.

DHFL case: ED freezes bank deposits worth ₹51.75 crore

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) on Friday said it has frozen bank deposits worth ₹51.75 crore under the anti-money laundering law as part of its fresh action in connection with an alleged bank-loan fraud worth over ₹34,000 crore, linked to the Dewan Housing Finance Corporation Ltd (DHFL).

The agency said in a statement that it conducted fresh searches in connection with the case on August 19. The ED probe under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) stems from a CBI FIR filed on a complaint from a consortium of 17 banks against DHFL and its promoters, Kapil Wadhawan and Dheeraj Wadhawan, for an alleged bank-loan fraud of ₹34,615 crore.

The ED said it has found that an immovable asset named "Hurtmore House" located in the United Kingdom was held in the name of Vanita Wadhawan, wife of Kapil Wadhawan.

This asset was disposed of through a series of trans-

Union Bank of India raises \$600 million from bonds

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

State-owned Union Bank of India has raised \$600 million from bonds issued to overseas investors to fund business growth.

The fund raised by issuing USD REG S Senior Unsecured Dual Tranche Notes due 2029 (3 years) and 2031 (5 years) of \$300 million each issued through Union Bank of India Dubai International Financial Centre (DIFC) branch, the bank said in a regulatory filing on Friday.

'Regulation S' tagged instruments are exempt from registration requirements of the US Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC)



and can be issued outside the US. The 3-year bonds carries a coupon rate of 5.230 per cent while 5-year 5.417 per cent to be paid semi-annually on February 28 and August 28 each year, it said. These bonds would be listed at NSE IFSC Limited, it said.



actions involving the creation of a fictitious liability in her name, the federal agency said.

"A purported loan agreement was executed between Al Jalore Trading FZE and Vanita Wadhawan and the said UK property was mortgaged pursuant thereto.

"Investigation has revealed that the arrangement was used to create an encumbrance over the foreign asset for the purpose of settling a liability in India arising out of the DHFL loan fraud," the ED said.

The property was sold this year and the sale considera-

tion was sent to the bank account of Al Jalore Trading FZE maintained in India, instead of being received by the registered owner, Vanita Wadhawan.

"The transaction, thus, involved dissipation of proceeds of crime, utilisation and disposal of a foreign asset in a manner intended to facilitate settlement of an Indian liability through a structured transaction involving foreign property and entities," the agency said.

During the searches, the ED froze the bank account of Al Jalore Trading FZE holding \$5.41 million (₹51.75 crore).

CBI arrests IRS officer, CGST superintendent in bribery case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The CBI has arrested a 2009-batch Indian Revenue Service (IRS) officer serving as an additional commissioner, Central Goods and Services Tax (CGST), in Maharashtra's Raigad district, along with a CGST superintendent and a private person, in a bribery case involving an alleged demand of ₹1.5 crore, officials said Friday.

The agency had earlier registered an FIR against CGST superintendent Rakesh Kumar Sinha based on allegations that he had demanded bribe to settle a GST and royalty matter involving a stone-quarrying firm, the agency said.

According to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the alleged bribe demand of ₹1.5 crore was later reduced to ₹40 lakh following negotiations. "The accused public servants had arranged for collection of the bribe amount through a private person and accordingly directed the complainant," a CBI spokesperson said in a statement.

A CBI team laid a trap on Thursday and caught



the private individual while allegedly accepting ₹40 lakh, the agency said.

The acceptance of the bribe amount was subsequently acknowledged by the accused superintendent of CGST Rakesh Kumar Sinha as well as the accused additional commissioner of CGST, 2009-batch IRS officer Vinay Kumar Kantheti.

All three accused have been arrested and are being produced before court, the spokesperson said. The CBI conducted searches at premises linked to the accused following the arrests, resulting in recovery of ₹43 lakh in cash and jewellery valued at about ₹90 lakh, the agency said.

VIT signs MoU with Columbia University, New York

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

VIT signed the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with Columbia University (Columbia Engineering), New York, USA, recently. This MoU was signed in the presence of Binaya Srikanta Pradhan, Consul General of India in New York, by VIT Chancellor Dr G Viswanathan and Sen Soulaymane Kachani, Dean of Academic Affairs and Global Partnerships

This historic partnership makes VIT the first Indian university to enter into a dual degree agreement with Columbia University, opening world-class academic pathways for engineering students on an international stage.

Emphasising the significance of the partnership, VIT Founder and Chancellor Dr G Viswanathan highlighted the institution's commitment to



delivering globally competitive education, describing the collaboration as a defining moment in the history of VIT. "This is a landmark agreement between VIT and Columbia University. We are proud to become the first Indian university to establish a dual degree programme with one of the world's most prestigious institutions. This

collaboration reflects VIT's unwavering commitment to providing globally competitive education and creating transformative international learning opportunities for our students."

Vice President Dr GV Selvam and Director — International Relations, Dr R Seenivasan, were also present during the occasion.

DAILY SUDOKU

3			2				1	5
	1	9		5			4	
	8	7		4				
				2				
1	7	8				5	2	6
			5					
			4			1	6	
	6			1		4	8	
4	3			6				7

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (28.8.26)

6	3	7	4	2	8	1	9	5
9	5	1	3	6	7	8	2	4
2	8	4	1	5	9	3	6	7
7	9	3	8	4	1	6	5	2
4	2	6	5	7	3	9	8	1
5	1	8	6	9	2	7	4	3
3	4	2	9	1	6	5	7	8
1	6	5	7	8	4	2	3	9
8	7	9	2	3	5	4	1	6

DOUBLE CROSSWORD SATURDAY | AUGUST 29, 2026

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	
			9					
10					11			
				12				
13		14				15		16
17					18			
				19				
20	21					22		23
24					25			
				26				
27						28		
				29				
30								

ACROSS

- Sportsman causing a runner hesitation (5)
- Crazy about ceramics? (5)
- Out-of-this-world skill in main distribution (7)
- Measures taken to elevate oneself? (5)
- Daunt from taking the car into the Kentish area (5)
- The prize is in the bag! (5)
- Nationalist ready to cause civil disturbance? (7)
- Had an encounter with the police (3)
- One spilling the gore of his victims? (4)
- Something to wear for the dance (6)

DOWN

- A serviceable container (6)
- Striker back at the cinema (6)
- Academician's princely title abroad (3)
- Strong drink (5)
- Anger with one's love? (7)
- Formerly going ahead at half pace (4)
- Artist who brought about change? (6)
- Fatherly bloomer? (5)
- The Dog and Duck's between the post office and the church (5)
- Lashed out with a right when vexed (5)
- Misguided lemon? (5)
- It's significant when Tom's out a bit late

ACROSS

- Protector of a soft little fellow (5)
- Her outcry is ruddy fruity! (6)
- Show sorrow at putting me out of work (4)
- Outwitted and put in the shade (3)
- Where, in sum, the rain is stormy (7)
- At school, they lead to a certain amount of better writing (5)
- Lord of Bolton? (5)
- Just the type to cow people (5)
- Something snappy to eat (7)
- Transport half a yard in play (5)
- Charges for tea at the Royal Society (5)

DOWN

- Something extra round in buns, perhaps (5)
- Men appearing in an operatic part abroad (7)
- Smoky city! (6)
- Waltz time (6)
- Roll up to dad with a sickly look (6)
- It can also be worn around the fifth of November (5)
- He's in jug (4)
- Sank in a little (3)

SOLUTION (28.8.26)

ACROSS	27. Carry on	DOWN	24. Laid hands
8. De-bat-ed	30. On ti-me	1. Resign	26. Slimmer
9. Reception	31. Edwa-R-d	2. E-east wi-nd	28. A-d-mission
13. Twi-S-t	32. Dents	3. Keeping back	29. W-aver-e'd
14. Par-ma(rev)	35. Carve	4. Get-a-ble	30. OC-curs
15. Lighten	36. No-l's-e	5. Res-ist	32. Detect-ed
16. Men-ti-on	37. A-t-tired	6. Stage fever	33. Saddle
17. Draws	39. Resi-due	7. Bolt	34. Inter-n-s
18. Force	41. S-pend	10. Stumps	38. Reason
20. Sh-red	42. Crawl	11. Prod-uce	40. Shot
22. Buckle	43. Bowindow	12. Sneeze	
23. Evin-C-e		19. Run down	
25. Cds-sack		21. Ro-O-ster	

BRIEFLY

Dean, Gagan set for WRC3 gravel challenge in Paraguay



Indian rally champions Dean Mascarenhas and co-driver Gagan Karumbaiah will return to the World Rally Championship this weekend for their second WRC3 outing of the season at Rally del Paraguay.

Driving a Ford Fiesta Rally3 prepared and serviced by PH Sport, the TSI Racing pair will face their first gravel rally of the season. Mangaluru's Dean and Kodagu's Gagan made their WRC debut at Rally Islas Canarias in April, finishing seventh in their class.

The 2025 Indian National Rally champions subsequently gained European experience, finishing 12th in the Rally3 class at Rally di Roma Capitale in July.

The Paraguay rally features 357.64kms of timed competition across 22 special stages on soft red-clay gravel.

"Our journey so far has been very positive, with a lot of learning and valuable experience. We're excited for our first gravel rally of the season," Dean said after Thursday's shakedown.

Mohan Nagarajan, MD of Sidvin Energy Engineering, said the team's European experience had helped Dean, Gagan and the entire programme prepare better for the WRC3 challenge. Founded in 2007, TSI Racing continues its efforts to provide Indian rally drivers with an international platform.

(PTI)

India U17 women to play two friendlies against Philippines



The India U17 women's team will continue its preparations for the AFC U17 Women's Asian Cup 2027 Qualifiers with two friendly matches against Philippines in Goa on September 26 and 29, respectively, the All India Football Federation (AIFF) said on Friday.

The venue for both matches will be confirmed at a later date. It will mark only the second meeting between India and the Philippines at this age level. The Southeast Asians won 2-0 in the AFC U16 Women's Championship 2017 Qualifiers.

Coached by Joakim Alexandersson, India are currently in Tashkent to play two friendlies against hosts Uzbekistan. The first one ended goalless on Thursday, while the second will take place on Sunday.

The games against the Philippines will be the Young Tigresses' last friendly outings before they travel to Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia, for the AFC U17 Women's Asian Cup China 2027 Qualifiers, which will be held from October 5 to 11. India will open their campaign against Iraq on October 5, before facing Syria on October 8 and hosting Malaysia on October 11.

(PTI)

People don't always know real story: Marijne defends pre-World Cup leave

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen

India women's hockey team chief coach Sjoerd Marijne on Friday insisted that his pre-World Cup leave did not compromise the team's preparations, asserting that he remained involved in every aspect of the build-up to the tournament in which India finished a credible fifth.

Marijne's decision to take leave before the World Cup came under scrutiny in a section of the media.

The Dutchman, however, said the team's preparation



remained on track with the support of his coaching staff. "I have seen every training, match, done meetings and had personal contact with the players, so it was not that I

Pragg becomes first Indian to win Grand Chess Tour title

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ St Louis (USA)

Grandmaster R Pragganandhaa became the first Indian to clinch the Grand Chess Tour title, beating Fabiano Caruana of the USA with a stunning comeback win in the grand finale.

Pragganandhaa made a remarkable turnaround on Thursday after trailing Caruana by six points at the start of the day at the Saint Louis Chess Club here.

The Indian eventually prevailed 15-13 to win his maiden GCT title and pocket \$200,000 as the winning purse.

The title win also guaranteed Pragganandhaa a spot in the next year's Grand Chess Tour along with Caruana and another



American, Wesley So, who defeated Vincent Keymer of Germany 18-12 to take third place.

"Honestly, I didn't think I had many chances today," Pragganandhaa told 'Chess.com'.

"It's not every day that you can get one win from Fabi, but to get two, it was important in the rapid."

The 21-year-old Chennai

lad, who has been mentored by five-time world champion Viswanathan Anand, started the day six points behind, but pulled another rabbit out of the hat and took a lead of two points after winning both the rapid games (four points to the winner per game).

It was even-stevens in the subsequent four games of blitz, with Pragganandhaa

and Caruana winning one each while the remaining two were drawn.

The two-point lead at the end of the rapid games proved decisive for the Indian Grandmaster.

The first game of the blitz section was a drawn affair before Caruana won the second to level the scores at 12-12.

A determined Pragganandhaa prevailed over his opponent in the third game to restore his two-point lead (14-12).

Had Caruana won the last blitz game, he would have forced two more games with the peculiar time control, followed by armageddon.

But, a draw was enough for Pragganandhaa to win the match, and he did just that to seal a famous title.

Portugal's Guarda FC signs Yohaán Benjamin for 2 years

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Portuguese club Guarda FC has signed Mumbai-born Indian youth international Yohaán Benjamin to a two-year deal, subject to international clearance and visa formalities.

The signing marks a significant step in Yohaán's European football journey and aligns with Guarda FC's ambition to create pathways for emerging talent from India, Asia and other developing football markets into European football.

"Signing for Guarda FC means a lot to me. It's another important step in my journey in Europe and an opportunity to keep growing, competing and proving myself at a higher level. I'm grateful to the club for believing in me



and giving me this opportunity," Benjamin said.

The midfielder began his football journey through football schools and academies, including Conscient Football Mumbai, Football Academy of Bangalore and Minerva Football Academy, before joining Shillong

Lajong in early 2022.

During his three years with the club, Yohaán progressed beyond the academy setup, gaining valuable experience alongside older players and across the club's senior and reserve setups.

He scored nine goals in the 2024 Shillong Premier League, helping Shillong Lajong clinch the title, while also contributing to the club's runners-up finish in the Meghalaya State League.

Jai Agarwal, CEO, Guarda Futebol Clube - Futebol, SAD, said, "Yohaán is exactly the kind of player we want at Guarda FC - ambitious, committed and hungry to succeed. We're delighted to have secured his signature on a two-year deal, subject to international clearance and visa formalities.

Future perfect for India women's hockey after WC turnaround, says Savita Punia

MONA PARTHSARATHI
■ Amstelveen (Netherlands)

India's women's hockey team has found a new belief in itself, veteran goalkeeper Savita Punia said after the side finished fifth at the ongoing World Cup, their best result in more than five decades.

The result marked a strong turnaround for India, who had failed to make the cut for the Paris Olympics 2024 and also had a tearful exit from the semi-final race at the recently concluded World Cup here.

The experienced Savita, who has 319 international



caps, in an interview with PTI, says the biggest change is not merely in the results but in the atmosphere inside the dressing room.

"After the arrival of coach Sjoerd Marijne and all the new support staff, we decided to have fun, laugh, talk and chat off the field. It wasn't like this before," said Savita, who is one cap away

from equalling India's record for most international appearances.

"We kept our thoughts to ourselves, but today every player speaks very openly to each other. Whatever I feel, I can frankly tell the team."

"The coaching staff has created such an environment that we feel a deep sense of doing our best. It's visible in the eyes, in the workouts and in the practice of all the players."

After missing the last four following their goalless draw to Australia, India defeated higher-ranked Germany 3-1 to finish fifth — their best result since 1974.

Neeraj Chopra qualifies for Diamond League Finals



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Indian javelin throw ace Neeraj Chopra has qualified for the Diamond League Finals to be held in Brussels on September 5 despite competing in just two events of the prestigious one-day meeting series.

Chopra secured 12 points after finishing second in both the Doha and Lausanne DL events on June 19 and August 21, respectively, to take the sixth spot in the standings and be eligible to compete in the winner-takes-all grand finale in Brussels.

The standings were updated at the end of the 14th and the last leg of the series in Zurich on Thursday.

Of the 14 Diamond League meetings of the year, five featured men's javelin throw and Chopra competed in just two.

The 28-year-old is on a comeback trail after recovering from a lower back injury that has troubled him since September last year. The injury delayed his return until the Doha Diamond League.

He was not 100 per cent fit at the recent Glasgow Commonwealth Games but was able to win a silver with

a season's best throw of 85.83m. He later improved that to 88.05m in the Lausanne Diamond League.

For jumps and throws, the top six in the standings will compete in the September 4-5 DL Finals in Brussels. One additional athlete per discipline may also compete via a national or global wildcard selection.

The DL Finals will be held over two days in Brussels, with 16 events to be organised on September 4 and the remaining 16 the next day. The men's javelin event will be held on September 5.

The winner will get a trophy and pocket a minimum of \$30,000. The eighth-place finisher will get \$1000.

If men's javelin is chosen as one of the Diamond+ disciplines, then the winner will pocket \$60,000.

Rising Sri Lankan star Rumesh Pathirage is at the top of the standings with 39 points, making him the favourite to walk away with the DL trophy in Brussels as well.

He competed in all five DL javelin events, won four and finished second in one, underlining his absolute dominance this season.

Rashid wins Telangana Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Vikarabad

Veteran golfer Rashid Khan ended a seven-year wait for victory with a closing five-under 67 that handed him the Telangana Open title on Friday.

The 35-year-old Delhi golfer (66-67-65-67) finished at 23-under 265 to secure his 15th professional title.

The three-strokes win at the Vooty Golf County was his 11th victory on the DP World PGTI.

He collected ₹15 lakh and moved up to sixth on the PGTI Order of Merit, taking his season earnings to ₹44,95,509.

Delhi's Honey Baisoya (72-



65-66-65) produced the best final-round score among the leading contenders, making nine birdies and two bogeys in a seven-under 65. He finished runner-up at 20-under 268.

Baisoya, winner of the World Players Championship in February, earned ₹10 lakh for his runner-up finish. He now occupies third place in the season rankings with total earnings of ₹51,72,092.

Pranavi Urs opens with 69, leads Indian challenge at KPMG Women's Irish Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Straffan (Ireland)

Pranavi Urs made a strong start to the KPMG Women's Irish Open, carding a three-under 69 to sit inside the top 10 after the opening round, while fellow Indians Diksha Dagar and Tvesa Malik were left battling to make the cut at The K Club here in wet conditions.



Pranavi, who has been one of India's better performers on the Ladies European Tour this season, with a Top-5 at Dutch Ladies and four other Top-20 finish-

es, produced a steady round in wet conditions at the Palmer South Course.

Starting from the 10th tee, she picked up three birdies on the back stretch on the

10th, 16th and 17th before adding another birdie on the first hole.

Pranavi, a winner last year in a mixed event played alongside men on the IGPL

Tour in India, dropped her only shot of the round at the eighth, her penultimate hole, to close with a three-under 69 and put herself in a strong position ahead of the second round.

Diksha, currently 11th on the LET Order of Merit, and Tvesa both carded 74s to be tied 69th and will need better scores in the second round to move safely inside the cut line.

Diksha, who also started from the 10th, had an inconsistent round with two birdies, two bogeys and a double bogey.

Roger Federer heads to the Tennis Hall of Fame and says he had the best time during his career

BRIAN MAHONEY
■ New York

Roger Federer loved to win, of course, and at the peak of his career almost always did.

All those victories and trophies he piled up alone would have made Federer remembered forever in tennis, but they were only part of the reason he enjoyed playing. He liked travelling to tournaments, meeting people and making new friends, whether they were on the other side of the net or sitting in the stands.

Only after he finished competing did Federer realise how much that impacted his legacy in the sport.

"I think when you retire, I think I said it before, that

there was a lot of talk also about maybe my personality and what I brought to the game overall when I wasn't on court, which I was a little surprised," Federer said. "I thought it was about, in the moment, forehands and backhands and saving break points and victories and all that stuff."

"But actually it becomes a little bit, not irrelevant eventually, but it's about what you were remembered for, how did you behave in the locker rooms or in the corridors or maybe with the media, or with the tournament directors, the ball kids."

Federer will have a chance to reflect back on it all Saturday when he is enshrined in the International Tennis Hall of

Fame in Newport, Rhode Island.

The 45-year-old from Switzerland, who will be honoured along with broadcaster and former player Mary Carillo, said it would be his first trip to Newport. That seemed surprising, given how many places he's gone for his tennis.

Sure, there were regular stops such as New York, London and Paris for Grand Slam tournaments, but there were also cities like Cape Town, South Africa, for an exhibition match against Rafael Nadal that drew nearly 52,000 fans; or Mexico City, for one against Alexander Zverev that drew more than 42,000.

Those were near the end of his career, when Federer was forced to limit his



schedule for health reasons. He hated having to do so, because he liked going to many places, even ones that didn't host the biggest events.

"For me, if I look back,

that's kind of what I'm very happy about, that I went through 25 years on tour, and actually felt like I made a lot of friends and a lot of people miss me," Federer said. "Same with fans. They

come up to me and say, 'What a shame you're not playing anymore.'"

"Then I get a flashback saying it was an amazing time, and I say it every time. I loved it, and it's a shame I can't be on the tour anymore. But it was a great, great time and I miss it dearly."

The fans clearly miss Federer. When he returned to the US Open this week for an exhibition, his first time playing in Flushing Meadows since 2019, the lines of fans waiting to get into Arthur Ashe Stadium resembled a night in the second week of the tournament, not well before it even began.

Federer won five straight US Open titles from 2004-08, during a stretch when he

compiled a 247-15 record from 2004-06 and reached a record 10 consecutive Grand Slam finals from 2005-07, winning eight. He went on to win 1,251 matches and 103 tournaments, including 20 Grand Slams.

"He's the best I've ever played against," Andre Agassi, Federer's opponent in the 2005 final, said in a video the US Open showed before Federer took the court Tuesday.

The way he won, with far more flair than some stuffy champions of the past but without the temper tantrums of others, earned him accolades that his skills alone couldn't. He won the ATP Tour's sportsmanship award every year from 2004-09, and again from 2011-17, and the fan favourite award

every year from 2003-21. Those came while earning prize money of nearly \$130.6 million.

Federer hits sometimes with his children - he and his wife Mirka are parents of two sets of twins - and tries to attend a few events a year to keep him connected to the sport. "I'm in a very comfortable place today, but I'm still happy to be out there and being in the tennis world from time to time, because it is the glue to everything that surrounds me still today," Federer said.

"I had the best time, had a lot of friends on tour, from players to people who were organisers, et cetera. So I hope that a lot of the players who retire also feel the same way about the game, because I care dearly."

(AP)

India Test takeaways: Padikkal, Suthar shine; bowling concerns

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Colombo

India arrived in Sri Lanka three weeks ago with several questions surrounding its Test team but Devdutt Padikkal's assured batting at number three is the biggest gain, while Manav Suthar has made a strong case to take over the baton from Ravindra Jadeja as the team's lead Test spinner for the next decade.

The management may also be delighted to see the efforts of batters, who copped fair bit of flak for their inability to tackle spin against New Zealand and South Africa at home, against Sri Lankan tweekers.

Padikkal was at the forefront of India's charge against spinners.

The Sri Lankan batters resorted to sweep and its varieties to nullify Indian spinners in the series, but Padikkal used a different method - astute back foot play and precise foot-work.



His early coach Mohammed Naseeruddin threw light into the Karnataka batter's approach. "We were working in that area before the series. If you stay in the crease then it is tough to play against spinners. So, we were training to get as close to the ball as possible, or come out and drive," Naseeruddin told PTI.

That diligence brought the desired result in the two-match series as Padikkal was adjudged player of the series for his 328 runs across three innings at an average of



109.33. It included two hundreds as well.

It seems that Padikkal has now put to bed the question on the best choice for the No. 3 slot for the foreseeable future, even when B Sai Sudharsan returns from his injury.

"If he continues to bat like this, then we will certainly give him (No. 3 slot)," skipper Shubhman Gill said in half-jest during the post-match press conference on Thursday.

Dhruv Jurel offered India a technical detour in terms

of tactical flexibility down the order. Originally a wicketkeeper-batter, Jurel now plays as a specialist batter at number 6 behind Rishabh Pant.

Jurel has this enviable ability to accelerate seamlessly from deep hibernation or calmly navigate through the rough seas.

In Galle, he made a quick 51 to build on Padikkal's hundred and at the Sinhalese Sports Club, the 25-year-old first supported an aggressive Pant before moving on to get a hundred for himself.

Then there is this comfort factor against pacers and spinners alike. During his hundred in the second Test here, Jurel faced 101 balls from spinners and milked 56 runs.

The pacers tried to bounce him out but shelved that ploy after bowling just seven bumpers, as Jurel peeled 15 runs off those deliveries. Now, he is India's chameleon at No. 6, shape-shifting as per conditions and situations. (PTI)

Ashwin tears into Rishabh Pant, rejects once-in-a-generation tag for keeper-batter

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Former India spinner Ravichandran Ashwin has questioned Rishabh Pant's shot selection and decision-making during the recent Test series against Sri Lanka, saying the flamboyant wicketkeeper-batter has not yet lived up to the expectations placed on him.

Pant, backed by the Indian team management for the wicketkeeper's role in the two-Test rubber, finished with 168 runs, including two half-centuries. But his aggressive approach and shot selection continued to attract scrutiny, with Ashwin making it clear that he expects more from a player who has now played over 50 Tests.

"My expectation from Rishabh Pant hasn't been fulfilled till now. I am very sorry. Sonal Dinusha had his strike rate up there. But the difference is high-risk options. When you have the game in your hand, these are all statements: 'That's how



Rishabh plays.' It is about what your team needs," Ashwin said on his YouTube channel 'Ash Ki Baat'.

Ashwin, who retired from international cricket last year, argued that Pant's attacking style cannot become an excuse for poor decision-making, particularly when a Test match is at a critical juncture. "Rishabh played a class knock in Sydney and Brisbane, but you couldn't have won that match without Washington Sundar and Shardul Thakur. It takes 11 cricketers to build a Test and win it in the last session of the game, but it

takes only one moment of foolishness to lose a Test," he said. Ashwin also rejected comparisons between Pant and former India opener Virender Sehwag and Australia great Adam Gilchrist, two players renowned for their aggressive approach in Test cricket.

"I am just talking about the times when these chances are being taken when the game is on the line. I love Rishabh the player. It is about playing situations in this format," he said.

"Sehwag and Gilchrist played high brand of cricket, but these two don't get

edged out while dancing down to Marco Jansen when your team is trailing by 500 runs. Don't place these marketing lines in front of me ever again."

Ashwin was equally critical of the notion that Pant deserves special backing because he is considered a "once-in-a-generation" player. He said the same level of faith should be extended to other young Indian players, including Yashasvi Jaiswal, while urging Pant to shoulder greater responsibility given his experience. "Don't give one player special treatment. This once-in-a-generation player backing, then give it to everyone. Jaiswal is also such a player," Ashwin said. "All I'm saying, Rishabh, is that he is experienced; he has played 50 Tests.

He needs to take responsibility. Don't come up with this 'once-in-a-generation' argument. It is because of his decision-making that he's not playing the other two formats.

England's seamers rip through Pakistan for 110, taking a 180-run lead at Lord's

FOSTER NIUMATA
■ London

England can anticipate finishing day two against Pakistan in the Lord's test as it started on Friday - batting.

England was all out for 290 in the morning, and its four seam bowlers then tore through Pakistan for 110 in 37.2 overs for a first-innings lead of 180.

Ollie Robinson had 4-11 off 13 overs, including six maidens. Jofra Archer had 3-26 from 11.2; Josh Tongue had two wickets and a luckless Gus Atkinson none.

Azan Awais was easily the standout for Pakistan. The novice opener, after scoring 0 and 9 in the first test defeat in Leeds last week, lasted to the 35th over, digging in against 102 balls to score 46.

He was out top-edging a pull to the boundary. Awais' innings was remarkable considering the next best runs in Pakistan's scoreboard were 20 extras.

He was the second-to-last man out at 106-8. Pakistan was effectively nine down because Awais' opening partner Imam-ul-Haq couldn't bat due to a low-grade left calf tear sustained while



fielding on Thursday.

It's questionable how much of a difference a full lineup would have made for Pakistan. The bowling was too good. Pakistan lost its most in-form batter Abdullah Shafique, right on

lunch, taken at 16-2 in 14.1 overs. Captain Babar Azam, coming back from a finger injury that made him miss the first test, walked out after lunch, hit a couple of boundaries through the covers, then edged Tongue to third slip. Saud Shakeel was the only batter other than Awais to reach double

figures. He had 16 from 16 balls when he was pinned by Robinson on his back leg. After a 30-minute rain delay, Mohammad Rizwan was also out LBW to Robinson. The wickets fell in a hurry from that point.

Ali Usman played Archer onto his stump, Khurram Shahzad edged Robinson to second slip, and Awais finally fell. Archer missed claiming Mohammad Ali, who was dropped by Joe Root at leg slip, but the fast bowler bowled Mohammad Abbas to end the innings. (AP)

BCCI trying to arrange county games for Auqib Nabi

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi

Keeping an eye on India's next Test tour of New Zealand, the BCCI is in talks with a few English counties to get a short-term contract for talented pacer Auqib Nabi during the final few rounds of the Championship.

Nabi, last Ranji season's highest wicket-taker with 60 scalps, and Gurnoor Brar didn't get a look-in in the playing XI for the two Tests against Sri Lanka recently.

While Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh Krishna have earned much-needed workload-related breaks, Gurnoor Brar will be linking up with



the North Zone side for the semi-final against South Zone starting November 30 at the Centre of Excellence.

"It was a decision taken by

the Indian team think-tank (team management and selection committee) that Gurnoor will be playing the Duleep Trophy. Already

Gautam Gambhir praises India's mental toughness

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

India head coach Gautam Gambhir on Friday praised his team's mental resilience to keep fighting till the end of their two-Test series, while giving a "special shoutout" to Sri Lanka's Sonal Dinusha.

While India crushed the hosts by 165 runs in the opening Test at Galle, Sri Lanka produced a remarkable fightback, particularly in the final innings and on the last day of the second Test at Colombo, with Dinusha leading their resistance.

India took the series 1-0.

Dinusha produced a memorable performance as he struck a second century of the Test on Thursday to force a draw in Colombo, keeping India winless, who had earlier imposed a follow-on against Sri Lanka. "Test cricket needs character, patience and mental toughness that's shown by our boys! Special shoutout to Sonal Dinusha for his exceptional performance!," Gambhir wrote on X. After scoring 103 in Sri Lanka's first innings, in which they were bowled out for 290 in reply to India's 503 for nine declared, Dinusha stood tall in



the second innings as well. Dinusha remained unbeaten on 133

(264 balls; 8 fours, 2 sixes) while forging crucial late partnerships which denied India one last push to make it 2-0.

The century in the second innings also made Dinusha only the third player in history to make a ton in each innings of a Test after their side was asked to follow on. The feat was earlier achieved by India's Vijay Hazare against Australia at Adelaide in 1948, and Andy Flower for Zimbabwe against South Africa at Harare in 2001. Dinusha also topped the batting charts with 420 runs in four outings as he had scored 100 and 84 in the first Test.

Pakistan opener Imam-ul-Haq suffers calf strain

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ London

Pakistan opener Imam-ul-Haq has sustained a low-grade calf strain, putting his participation in the remainder of the second Test against England in doubt, the Pakistan Cricket Board said on Friday.

Imam suffered the injury on the opening day of the Test and spent time off the field during Thursday's evening session.

"Scans later confirmed a low-grade calf strain and Imam is currently receiving treatment under the supervision of the Pakistan medical team," the PCB said in a statement.

"His participation in the remainder of the Test depends on treatment leading to recovery," it added.

Imam had opened the batting with young Azan Awais in the first Test at Leeds, which Pakistan lost by an innings inside three days.



Hope Imran Khan is treated with dignity: Pat Cummins

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Sydney

Australia's Test and ODI skipper Pat Cummins on Friday threw his weight behind the ongoing former international captains' campaign seeking medical care for jailed Pakistan legend Imran Khan and said he should be treated with dignity.

The 73-year-old Imran has been jailed in Rawalpindi since 2023 after being convicted on corruption charges. He recently underwent a medical examination in Islamabad before being sent

back to prison.

His sons, Sulaiman and Kasim, have expressed fears about his safety, saying that attempts are being made to kill him. Cummins said his family should get access to Imran. "Adding my support here to GC (Greg Chappell) and the other former international captains. I hope the court ordered medical assessment be allowed to run its course, and that family visits continue. 'I hope Imran Khan is treated with the dignity anyone deserves,'" Cummins posted on 'X' quoting a short clip of Chappell in which he is seen expressing his own



concerns about Imran's well being. Cummins has become perhaps the first active crick-

eter to voice his support for Imran's medical care after 21 former captains, including India great Sunil Gavaskar, wrote a letter to Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, demanding humane treatment of the legendary former all-rounder.

A former Pakistan Prime Minister himself, Imran is an iconic name in the country's cricket history, having led the national team to its first and only ODI World Cup title back in 1992.

He has denied any wrongdoing and described the action against him as politically motivated.

Being a trans-athlete can be isolating, was served with silence by BCCI: Anaya Bangar

POONAM MEHRA
■ New Delhi

It's been lonely, it's been brutal, but it's also been worth it. On the cusp of reclaiming her cricketing life, trans-athlete Anaya Bangar is unruffled by what the sceptics and critics have to say as she feels a bit of "education" is all it would take for them to come around.

"Served with silence" by the BCCI when she first approached the Board for assistance in becoming a part of India's women's cricket set-up, the 25-year-old found support from Cricket Australia, which allowed her

to compete at the community shield level.

In an exclusive interview to PTI, Anaya said she has been through a roller-coaster ride since the beginning of her transition in 2022, a process which culminated with a gender affirming surgery in March this year.

"...when you're transitioning, and when you're a trans-athlete, during this political climate in this world, it can get very isolating. You feel very lonely, you feel like there's no one who really understands out there," she said. "Everyone out there is trying to give you solutions, when you know that your

own case is the right one. You know what is happening with you is injustice. So, during all of this, just the fact of being with myself, solitude has helped me a lot throughout all this," added the left-arm spin bowling all-rounder, whose father is former India player and decorated coach Sanjay Bangar.

"Right now, just hearing the news about Cricket Australia clearing me, and basically providing me a path to play women's cricket, to play cricket as who I am is huge for me."

Anaya had given up hope of ever playing the game and although she is grateful



towards her family for the support it offered for "neces-

sities", it is the universe that, she feels, changed her cir-

cumstances for the better. "To be honest, emotionally, it's just been all by myself, but I'm grateful for the support for the necessities that I had from my family.

"I never thought that I'll be able to get (to) play cricket ever since the day I started transitioning. I just tried to put myself out there and see what happens, and whatever works, works. And throughout all this, I think the universe has backed me a lot, and here we are," she said.

Anaya was still recovering from the after-effects of her surgery when she approached Cricket Australia's Head of Integrity

Jacqui Partridge in June after coming to know about their policy of allowing trans players in women's cricket.

The process thereafter was smooth and swift unlike the lack of response that she encountered on approaching the BCCI. She hoped the Indian Board would figure out a policy for future.

"...it is very disappointing and heartbreaking that I was served with silence.

"I knew that transitioning was going to make me steer away from cricket...I hope that BCCI is open to this and tries to form policies surrounding this topic, since I'm the first case in India.

"I would be happy to be a part of the team and provide my insights and gatherings throughout my whole journey and what would work best for our country and women's sport in the future," she said. The experience though made her "stronger and wiser". "To be honest, transitioning was always about being happy and comfortable in my own skin.

And I had to take the necessary steps during that time in my life to basically give up the sport that I loved. Go through major changes, go through major family dynamic changes and everything," she said.